

Karnataka: State Overview
Policy, Politics And Governance

22nd August 2026

Executive Summary		
Register	Key Finding	So What
Overview	Karnataka enters the second half of 2026 with three simultaneous stories in motion: a caste settlement moving from survey to statute, a Chief Ministerial transition executed under an informal 2023 pact, and a fiscal position sliding from Front Runner to Performer on the NITI Aayog Fiscal Health Index, even as Government funds its largest-ever welfare compact.	This Note reads the state across ten registers to build a single client-ready picture for a Cabinet colleague or party strategist.
Caste and Reservation	The Socio-Economic and Educational Survey, accepted by Cabinet in April 2025, found an OBC bloc at seventy per cent of those enumerated and proposed Lingayat, Vokkaliga and Muslim quota increases that would push the combined OBC-SC-ST reservation past 75%.	This breaches the Indra Sawhney ceiling of fifty per cent and invites both a legislative fight and a near-certain constitutional challenge once notified.
Leadership Transition	Shri D.K. Shivakumar was sworn in as Chief Minister on 3 June 2026, completing a caste-balanced handover with Dr G. Parameshwara as Deputy Chief Minister and Dr Yathindra S., son of former Chief Minister Dr Siddaramaiah, retained in Cabinet.	The arrangement manages the Congress coalition but does not resolve the risk of two power centres ahead of 2028.
Fiscal Position	The five welfare guarantees, budgeted at ₹51,599 crore for 2026-27, sit against a third consecutive year of revenue deficit, a fiscal deficit of ₹97,449 crore, and liabilities of ₹8.24 lakh crore, or 24.9% of Gross State Domestic Product.	This is inside the Karnataka Fiscal Responsibility Act band but leaves a narrowing margin for capital expenditure on water, transit and higher education.
Bengaluru	The city anchors close to forty per cent of India's software exports in a good year and hosts the country's largest Global Capability Centre cluster, yet it has not held a full municipal council election since 2015; the 2024-25 Greater Bengaluru Governance Act now faces a Seventy-fourth Amendment challenge.	Bengaluru is simultaneously Karnataka's principal fiscal asset and its principal governance liability.
Electoral Pattern	No party has won a comfortable second consecutive Assembly term without a mid-course crisis, and 2023 Assembly and 2024 Lok Sabha results in the same 28 Bengaluru metro seats moved in opposite directions.	Karnataka's electorate routinely separates its state and national choices; a 2028 strategy built on 2024 Lok

Register	Key Finding	So What
		Sabha assumptions would misread the state contest.
Unresolved Distribution Questions	The Cauvery award, the Belagavi border dispute, and the Article 371J special status for Kalyana Karnataka remain live and unresolved distribution questions.	Karnataka's constraint is not resource scarcity but distribution of water, Cabinet berths, municipal power and the Bengaluru surplus.

I. Part I: Introduction & Context

A. Etymology and Origin

Karnataka's name is usually read as a Kannada compound of karu and nadu, meaning elevated land. Karunadu may also be read as Karu (black) and nadu (Region), as a reference to the black cotton soil found in the Bayaluseeme region of Karnataka. The British used the word Carnatic (sometimes Karnatak) to describe both sides of Peninsular India, south of the Krishna River.¹ Chief Minister D. Devaraj Urs renamed Mysore State to Karnataka on 1 November 1973, writing linguistic identity into the state's official name.² The claim to a distinct Kannada political identity predates the modern state by more than a millennium: the Halmidi inscription of around 450 CE is the earliest known Kannada inscription **and a fifth-Century copper coin discovered at Banavasi**, and anchors a literary-political claim older than the princely house of Mysore.³ The 1973 renaming was accordingly not a cosmetic act; it closed the gap between the 1956 linguistic state formed under the States Reorganisation Act and a civilisational name that predates it.⁴

B. State at a Glance

Karnataka covers 191,791 square kilometres, making it the sixth-largest state in India by area, with a projected 2026 population of 6.91 crore.⁵ The state's Gross State Domestic Product for 2025–26 stands at ₹30.7 lakh crore at current prices.⁶ Administratively, Karnataka is organised into 31 districts and four revenue divisions, with a legislature comprising 224 Assembly seats, 75 Legislative Council seats, 12 Rajya Sabha seats, and 28 Lok Sabha seats.⁷ Kannada is the official language, and Bengaluru is the capital.⁸ As per the **2011 Census**, Karnataka had **29,340 villages, 220 statutory towns and 127 census towns**.⁹ Note: Explained: How Vijayanagara became Karnataka's 31st district.¹⁰

Hampi, Vokkalga supports Congress, Lingat supports BJP, KURba is like SC/ ST. Consider Karnataka in three things.

¹ [A Handbook of Karnataka](#) (Page 12)

² [A Handbook of Karnataka](#) (Page 109)

³ [A Handbook of Karnataka](#) (Page 1)

⁴ [A Handbook of Karnataka](#) (Page 109)

⁵ [A Handbook of Karnataka](#) (Page 12 refer for the square kilometres)

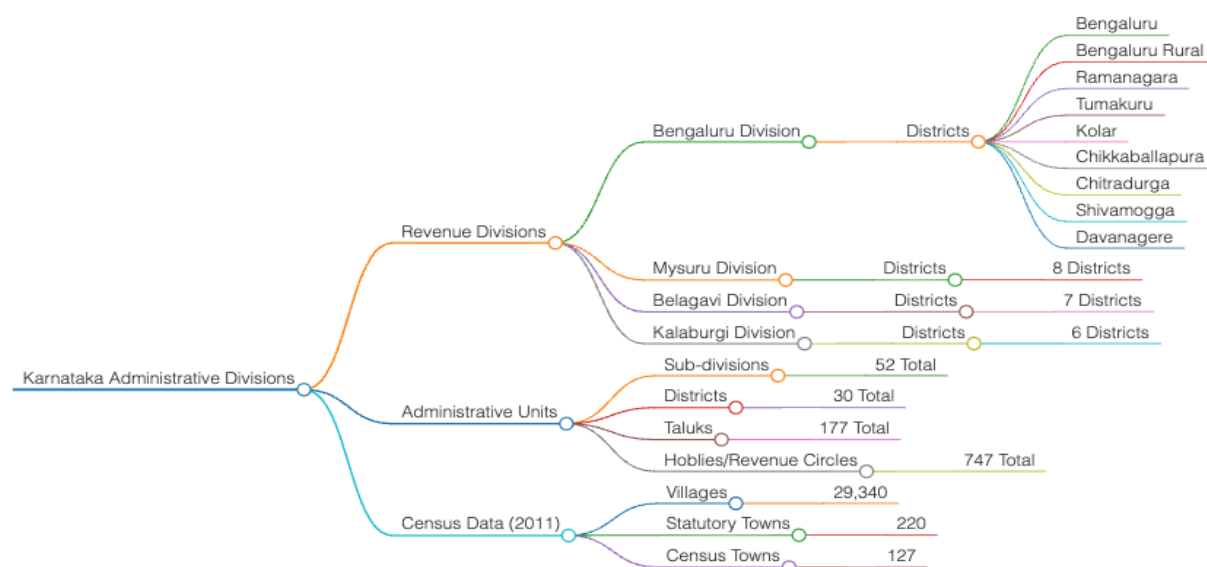
⁶ [PRS India](#)

⁷ [Magmemedal](#)

⁸ [The New India Express](#)

⁹ [A Handbook of Karnataka](#)

¹⁰ [Deccan Chronicle](#)



C. Physiographic Regions

Karnataka has four physiographic regions: the Northern Karnataka Plateau, Central Karnataka Plateau, Southern Karnataka Plateau, and Karnataka Coastal Region. The Northern Karnataka Plateau covers Belagavi, Bidar, Vijayapura, Bagalkot, Kalaburgi and Yadgir and generally has an elevation of 300–600 m. The Central Karnataka Plateau includes areas around the Tungabhadra basin, with elevations of 450–700 m. The Southern Karnataka Plateau largely covers the Cauvery basin, with elevations of 600–900 m, while some residual hills reach 1,500–1,750 m are found in the Biligirirangan hills of Mysuru district and the Brahmagiri range of Kodagu district.¹¹

D. Water Resources

The Karnataka Coastal Region covers Dakshina Kannada, Udupi and Uttara Kannada and lies between the Western Ghats and the Arabian Sea. It consists of coastal plains and the Western Ghats and has rivers, creeks, waterfalls, peaks and hill ranges. The coastal belt has an average width of 50–80 km and covers a distance of about 267 km from north to south. The northern Western Ghats have elevations of 450–600 m, while the southern parts range from 900–1,500 m.¹²

1. Krishna Basin

The Krishna River is an inter-State river that rises in the Western Ghats near Mahabaleshwar, Maharashtra, at 1,337 m and flows about 1,400 km west to east through Maharashtra, Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh. About 43.74% of the Krishna Basin lies in Karnataka, and nearly 60% of Karnataka's

¹¹ [A Handbook of Karnataka](#) (Page 22)

¹² [A Handbook of Karnataka](#) (Page 22)

area falls within the basin. Its major tributaries include the Bhima, Tungabhadra, Ghataprabha and Malaprabha, with Tungabhadra being the largest and most important tributary.

2. Cauvery Basin

The Cauvery River originates in the Western Ghats of Kodagu district and flows for 804 km through Karnataka and Tamil Nadu before entering the Bay of Bengal. About 42.2% of its basin lies in Karnataka, where the river flows for 320 km. Its major Karnataka tributaries include the Hemavati, Harangi, Kabini, Suvarnavati, Shimsha and Arkavati.

3. Godavari Basin

Only a small part of the Godavari Basin lies in Karnataka, mainly in Bidar district. The Manjra, a tributary of the Godavari, drains this area, with a catchment of about 4,405 sq. km in Karnataka.

4. West-Flowing Rivers

The major west-flowing rivers are Sharavati, Kali, Gangavali (Bedti), Aghanashini and Netravati. They rise on the western side of the Western Ghats and flow into the Arabian Sea, mainly through Uttara Kannada and Dakshina Kannada. Their total catchment area is about 26,214 sq. km, and they receive heavy rainfall from the southwest monsoon, particularly between June and August.

C. Physical Divisions

The state divides into three distinct physical regions. Karavali, the coastal belt, runs along 320 kilometres of Arabian Sea coastline and combines ports, fisheries and a Tulu-Konkani-Kannada linguistic mix with high rainfall and a distinct political culture. Malnad, the Western Ghats hill country, is the state's ecological spine, producing coffee, areca and cardamom and hosting a UNESCO serial natural heritage site. Bayaluseeme, the open Deccan plains, is a dryland-agriculture zone anchored by the Krishna-Tungabhadra command area and forms the state's demographic and political heartland.¹³

E. Mountain Ranges

Karnataka has high mountains, plateaus, residual hills and coastal plains. Most of the state is a plateau with an elevation of 600–900 metres, while the landscape is generally undulating with mountains and deep ravines. The coastal belt along the Arabian Sea has elevations below 300 metres. Karnataka has several peaks above 1,500 metres, including Mullayanagiri (1,925 m), Kudremukh (1,895 m), Pushpagiri (1,908 m), and Bababudangiri (1,894 m). About 48.81% of the state's area lies between 600 and 1,350 metres, while 43.51% lies between 300 and 600 metres.¹⁴

F. Climate and Drought

Karnataka has three main climatic regions: Coastal Karnataka, North Interior Karnataka, and South Interior Karnataka. The coastal region has a tropical monsoon climate with heavy rainfall from June to September. Southern Karnataka mainly has a hot, seasonally dry tropical savanna climate, while most of northern Karnataka has a hot, semi-arid tropical steppe climate. The main seasons are winter (January–February), summer (March–May), monsoon, and post-monsoon (October–December). April

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¹⁴ [A Handbook of Karnataka](#) (Page 22)

and May are the hottest months, while December and January are the coldest. The highest temperature recorded was 45.6°C at Raichur in May 1928, while the lowest was 2.8°C at Bidar in December 1918.¹⁵

G. Forests

The total recorded forest area of the State is 43,382 sq. km. The State has a network of Protected Areas with 5 Tiger Reserves, 5 National Parks, 30 Wildlife Sanctuaries, 15 Conservation Reserves and 1 Community Reserve.¹⁶

H. Society I

1. Religion

The 2011 Census remains the last official religious enumeration for Karnataka: Hindus at 84.0%, Muslims at 12.9%, Christians at 1.9%, Jains at 0.7%, and other or not-stated categories at 0.5%. Muslim and Christian population. A politically significant share of the Hindu category is separately claimed as a distinct Lingayat religious identity, a demand that remains unresolved.¹⁷ The Jain population, small in headcount, carries a disproportionate coastal commercial capital and centres on the Shravanabelagola sacred geography.

2. Caste Census

The Socio-Economic and Educational Survey, conducted in 2015 and accepted by the state Cabinet in April 2025, has reopened Karnataka's reservation debate. The survey found an Other Backward Classes share of seventy per cent among those enumerated, the largest single social bloc in the count; a Scheduled Caste population of 1.09 crore; and a Scheduled Tribe population of 42.8 lakh, or roughly seven per cent of those enumerated. A proposed combined OBC and Scheduled Caste/Scheduled Tribe reservation, including Muslims classified under Category 2B, would move from a current 51% to more than 75%, breaking the fifty per cent ceiling set by the Supreme Court in Indra Sawhney. Table 1 sets out the headline community counts, which are the most politically contested rows in the report.¹⁸

Bloc	Share	Headcount	Reservation Politics
Lingayat / 3B	11.1%	66.4 lakh	Quota proposed 8% (from 5%)
Vokkaliga / 3A	10.3%	61.7 lakh	Quota proposed 7% (from 4%)
Muslims / 2B	12.6%*	75.3 lakh	Quota proposed 8% (from 4%)
Most backward / 1	—	new 1A + 1B	Nomadic / Kuruba re-stack

Table 1: Headline community shares in the Socio-Economic and Educational Survey. *75.25 lakh of 5.98 crore enumerated persons; some political readings have circulated a figure of 18%. Source: internal PPGF briefing, August 2026, citing the Survey report.

¹⁵ [A Handbook of Karnataka](#) (Page 36-37)

¹⁶ [Karnataka Forest Department](#)

¹⁷ [The Times of India: Demand to accord separate religion tag for Lingayats gains momentum again](#)

¹⁸ PPGF, "Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance", internal briefing, August 2026, slide 11.

So what: the Survey's numbers, not only its recommendations, are now the fight. A quota architecture that raises Lingayat, Vokkaliga and Muslim shares simultaneously, while lifting the combined OBC-SC-ST ceiling past 75%, invites both a legislative battle over the Karnataka reservation Act and a near-certain constitutional challenge once implemented, given the Indra Sawhney ceiling. Any client-facing note on Karnataka reservation policy should treat the Survey headcounts as contested data, not settled fact, until Government notifies a final quota order.

J. Society III – Caste Dynamics

Four voter blocs continue to determine Karnataka governments, with geography and narrative mattering more than raw numbers. The Lingayat community, historically the largest single Hindu community in the state's political imagination, is organised around Veerashaiva mathas and Panchamasali sub-caste assertion and forms the Bharatiya Janata Party's oldest social base in the state, though this base is now more fractured than at its 2008–18 peak. The Vokkaliga community forms the landed agrarian core of southern Karnataka, delivering the Janata Dal (Secular) family vote alongside Congress organisational strength built by Shri D.K. Shivakumar, and holds a decisive say in the Mandya, Hassan, Ramanagara and Bengaluru Rural belt. The AHINDA coalition — Alpasankhyataru (minorities), Hindulidavaru (backward classes) and Dalitaru (Scheduled Castes) — traces to Shri Devaraj Urs's social engineering and forms Dr Siddaramaiah's electoral brand, combining Kuruba, Other Backward Class, Dalit and minority arithmetic against the two dominant land-owning castes. Minority communities, concentrated on the coast, in the cities and in the north-east, include Muslims voting largely as a consolidated Congress bloc across most election cycles, a Christian population on the coast, and a Jain mercantile presence; the Category 2B quota question is now a mobilisation device for multiple political actors.¹⁹

Analytical Takeaways – Part I

1. The Socio-Economic and Educational Survey has converted Karnataka's caste question from a sociological description into an active legislative and constitutional risk, given the proposed breach of the fifty per cent reservation ceiling.
2. Sixteen permanently drought-prone districts mean that disaster-management and irrigation-subsidy politics are a fixed annual governance cost, not a contingency, for any Government in office.
3. The Lingayat identity demand and the AHINDA coalition remain the two organising poles of Karnataka's social politics; any state-level strategy document should map candidate selection and welfare messaging against these four blocs rather than against religion alone.
4. Western Ghats conservation policy sits at the intersection of climate commitment, tribal rights and mining or forest-produce livelihoods, and will continue to generate friction regardless of which party governs.

¹⁹PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 12.

IV. Part II – Culture

A. Heritage and Geographical Indication Tags

Karnataka holds four major heritage designations that combine conservation obligations with statutory land-use management. Hampi, inscribed in 1986, is managed as the former Vijayanagara metropolis through the Hampi World Heritage Area Management Authority and its buffer-zone rules. Pattadakal, inscribed in 1987, preserves the Chalukya laboratory of Nagara and Dravida temple architecture on a single river bend. The Hoysala temple ensemble at Belur, Halebidu and Somanathapura was inscribed in 2023, treating soapstone craftsmanship as a civilisational export. The Western Ghats, inscribed in 2012 as part of a serial natural site, includes several clusters within Karnataka. Alongside these, the state holds 39 Geographical Indication tags — including Mysore Silk, Mysore Pak, Coorg Coffee, Bidriware, Ilkal and Molakalmuru sarees, Channapatna toys, Kinhal crafts, Udupi Mattu Gulla brinjal and Nanjangud rasabale banana — that together function as a single craft-economy policy instrument.²⁰

B. Festivals and Soft Power

State patronage for festivals is structured as a graded grant system mapped onto tourism circuits. Mysuru Dasara, the royal-state festival, remains the flagship grant at ₹1 crore. The Hampi Utsav and the Kambala Utsav — the coastal buffalo race, now protected by dedicated legislation rather than treated purely as folk custom — each receive ₹1 crore, as does the Chalukya-Lakkundi circuit covering north Karnataka's temple towns. Regional festivals tied to Hoysala, Kadamba, Bidar and Karavali heritage receive ₹50 lakh, while adventure-tourism festivals — rock climbing, surfing and kayaking — receive ₹10 lakh as an emerging tourism product.²¹

C. Cinema and Food Systems

Kannada cinema, or Sandalwood, has carried Karnataka's cultural narrative into the Hindi and global entertainment stream through films such as KGF and Kantara, prompting Government to treat film as industrial policy through rebates and studio infrastructure. Coastal Yakshagana performance traditions feed directly into popular cinema's visual grammar, functioning as a supply chain rather than a separate folk tradition. Karnataka's culinary economy has become a national franchise model through Udupi restaurants, alongside dishes such as bisi bele bath, ragi mudde, Coorg pork preparations, Mangalorean fish curry and filter coffee; Geographical Indication foods now sit alongside a large hotel and cloud-kitchen sector concentrated in Bengaluru.²²

D. Sports and Public Life

Sport in Karnataka combines large public infrastructure with distinct regional loyalties. The M. Chinnaswamy Stadium and the Indian Premier League have made cricket, and the Royal Challengers Bengaluru franchise in particular, a more reliable marker of Bengaluru civic identity than many political parties. The Kambala legislation, balancing the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals Act against coastal custom, represents culture codified as statute. Kodagu's hockey nurseries and rural kho-kho and kabaddi participation outrun stadium

²⁰PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 13.

²¹PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 14.

²²PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 15.

sport in headcount, while the state's National Games legacy and university sporting infrastructure continue to await a second cricket venue that functions reliably.²³

Analytical Takeaways – Part II

1. Karnataka's cultural assets are already monetised through a formal state-grant architecture; the policy gap is less about recognition and more about converting heritage sites into overnight-stay tourism revenue, particularly in the north.
2. The Sandalwood film industry and the Geographical Indication basket are underused instruments of soft power that could be more deliberately linked to the state's investment-promotion messaging.
3. Cricket and Kambala illustrate a broader pattern: sport in Karnataka is as much a legislative and identity question as a recreational one, and any public-life messaging strategy should treat it accordingly.

²³PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 16.

V. Part III – History

A. Ancient Roots

The Kadambas emerged around 345 CE under Mayurasharma, who established his power at Banavasi after rebelling against the Pallavas. The Talagunda inscription provides an important account of his background and rise to power. The Kadambas were among the earliest major dynasties to establish an independent centre of political power in the Karnataka region. Their importance also lies in their contribution to Kannada language and culture, temple architecture and irrigation works. The Halmidi inscription, from around 450 CE, is particularly significant because it is widely accepted as the oldest surviving full-length Kannada inscription, providing important evidence of Kannada's early use in formal records. Under rulers such as Kakusthavarma, the dynasty also developed wider political connections through alliances with powerful contemporary kingdoms. Around 540 CE, the Kadambas were overthrown by the Chalukyas of Badami. Later, Kadamba branches from Hanagal and Goa continued to rule as subordinate powers under the Chalukyas of Kalyana.²⁴

B. Chalukyas

The Chalukyas of Badami emerged around 540 CE, overthrowing the Kadambas and establishing one of the most powerful kingdoms in the Deccan, with Vatapi (Badami) as their capital. Under Pulakeshin II (c. 608–642 CE), the empire expanded from the Narmada to the Cauvery, while his victory over Harsha in the north strengthened Chalukyan power. The dynasty is especially remembered for its remarkable rock-cut and structural architecture at Badami, Aihole and Pattadakal. Pulakeshin II's reign also saw conflict with the Pallavas, who captured Badami around 642 CE. The Chalukyas later recovered under Vikramaditya I, and Vikramaditya II subsequently defeated the Pallavas and entered Kanchi. However, repeated wars weakened the dynasty, and Chalukyan power finally declined under Kirtivarman II around 757 CE, when the Rashtrakutas rose to power.²⁵

C. Rashtrakutas

The Rashtrakutas of Malkhed rose in 753 CE when Dantidurga overthrew Kirtivarman II of the Badami Chalukyas. Under rulers such as Dhruva and Govinda III, they expanded their power across the Deccan and into North India, while Amoghavarsha I promoted scholarship and Kannada literature, including *Kavirajamarga*. Their major architectural legacy includes the monolithic Kailasa Temple, Dashavatara Shrine at Ellora, Jogeshwara near Mumbai and Elephanta, along with temples at Sirivala, Sulepet, Gadikeshwar, Adaki, Sedam, Handarki, Mogha, Naragund, Nidagundi, Naregal, Ron, Savadi, Badami, Banashankari, Pattadakal and Hampi. The dynasty remained a major Deccan power until the 10th century.²⁶

D. Hoysalas

The Hoysalas continued the artistic tradition of the Kalyana Chalukyas, with their finest temples at Belur, Halebidu and Somanathapura. Under Vishnuvardhana, the defeat of the Cholas and liberation of

²⁴ [A Handbook of Karnataka](#) Page 72

²⁵ [A Handbook of Karnataka](#) Page 76

²⁶ [A Handbook of Karnataka](#) Page 77-78

Gangavadi led to the construction of the Kirtinarayana Temple at Talakad and Vijayanarayana (Chennakeshava) Temple at Belur. His commander Ketamalla built the Hoysaleswara Temple at Halebidu. The source also records Hoysala temples at Maddur, Marehalli, Tonnur, Kikkeri, Bhadravathi, Banawara, Basaral, Arasikere, Aralaguppe, Amritapura, Melkote, Nagamangala, Kaidala, Javagal, Mosale, Nuggehalli, Turuvekere, Govindanahalli and Shravanabelagola, among many others.²⁷

E. Malik Kafur's Southern Campaigns (1310–11)

Malik Kafur, the powerful general of Alauddin Khalji, led Delhi Sultanate campaigns into the Deccan and South India. After subjugating the **Yadavas of Devagiri** and defeating the **Kakatiyas of Warangal (1309–10)**, he advanced into the territories of the **Hoysalas and the far south**. These campaigns brought substantial wealth to Delhi and formed part of the wider political upheaval that weakened the established kingdoms of South India before the emergence of **Vijayanagara in 1336**.²⁸

F. Bahmani Kingdom (1347–1520)

Founded by Alla-Ud-Din Hasan at Kalaburagi in 1347, the Bahmani Kingdom repeatedly clashed with Vijayanagara and later split into five Shahi kingdoms of the Deccan. It made important contributions to Indo-Saracenic architecture, including the Jamia Masjid at Kalaburagi, Solha Kamb Mosque at Bidar, Bande Nawaz Dargah and Sath Gumbaz at Kalaburagi, and Gawan's Madrasa at Bidar. The Adil Shahis of Vijayapura, one of the successor kingdoms, later built the Gol Gumbaz.

G. Vijayanagara

Vijayanagara was founded in 1336 by Harihara and Bukka of the Sangama dynasty on the Tungabhadra, with the kingdom expanding under successive rulers. Krishnadevaraya (1509–29), the great Tuluva ruler, marked a period of military expansion, scholarship and cultural patronage, including the construction of the Krishnaswamy Temple. The defeat at Rakkasa Tangadi (Talikota) in 1565 led to the destruction of Vijayanagara and the sack of its capital, after which the rulers shifted to Penugonda, Chandragiri and Vellore. Hampi remains notable for its Vijayanagara architecture, including the Hazara Rama Temple, Krishnaswamy Temple, Stone Chariot at the Vitthala Temple Complex, large prakaras, rayagopuras, and Kalyana and Sabha Mantapas with monolithic pillars.²⁹

H. Mysuru under the Wodeyars

The Mysuru royal family, formerly a feudatory of Vijayanagara, became independent as the empire weakened. **Raja Wodeyar (1578–1617)** secured Srirangapattana in 1610, while **Kantirava Narasimha (1638–59)** resisted Vijayapura, expanded the territory, built the **Narasimha Temple at Srirangapattana**, and issued **Kanthirayi panams**. **Chikkadevaraya (1673–1704)** expanded Mysuru, strengthened its revenue system, secured Bengaluru and its surroundings from the Mughals on lease, and patronized Kannada writers. Weak rulers later led to the **usurpation of power by Haider Ali in 1761**.³⁰

²⁷ [A Handbook of Karnataka](#) Page 83-84

²⁸ [Malik Kafur's Invasion of Madurai: The Delhi Sultanate's Conquest of the Pandya Kingdom](#)

²⁹ [A Handbook of Karnataka](#) Page 84

³⁰ [A Handbook of Karnataka](#) Page 93

I. Hyder Ali & Tipu Sultan: Mysuru Resists British Rule

Hyder Ali (1761–82) expanded Mysuru in all directions, merged the Keladi Kingdom with Mysuru, strengthened its military and used cavalry extensively. He allied with the French against the British and fought in the First Anglo-Mysuru War before dying during the Second Anglo-Mysuru War in 1782. Tipu Sultan (1782–99) continued his father's anti-British policy, fought the Third and Fourth Anglo-Mysuru Wars, promoted sericulture, industries, overseas trade and rocket technology, and sought assistance from France, Turkey and Afghanistan. He died fighting the British at Srirangapatna in 1799. Following his defeat, the British took control of Mysuru, handed parts of the territory to their allies, and crowned **Krishnaraja Odeyar III** as ruler of the reduced Mysuru Kingdom.

J. Wodeyar III : Restoration & the Model State

The **1881 Rendition** restored Mysuru's administration to **Chamarajendra Odeyar**, the adopted son of Krishnaraja III. Under capable Diwans such as **Rangacharlu and Sheshadri Iyer**, the kingdom developed its administrative institutions. Rangacharlu founded the **Mysuru Representative Assembly in 1881**, initially with 144 nominated members, laying the groundwork for responsible government; from 1891, members were elected from among revenue-paying landlords, merchants and graduates. He also encouraged **Kannada literature and scholarship**. After his death in 1894, **Krishnaraja Odeyar IV** became king, with **Queen-Mother Vanivilas as Regent**, while Sheshadri Iyer continued as Diwan until 1901.³¹

K. Modernisation

The Mysuru princes were enlightened administrators and patrons of **learning, literature, music and fine arts**. **Krishnaraja Wadiyar IV (1902–1940)** combined a modern outlook with rapid development of the State, while his brother **Kanthirava Narasimharaja Odeyar** supported the fine arts and Kannada literature. **Diwan P.N. Krishnamurthy (1901–06)** modernised administration, improved office procedures and records, and founded the **Co-operative Department (1906)**. **Diwan V.P. Madhava Rao** established the **Legislative Council (1907)**, promoted forest conservation and founded the **Central Co-operative Bank**. This administrative foundation was followed by the industrial and educational expansion under **Sir M. Visvesvaraya and Sir Mirza M. Ismail**, making Mysuru a modern and model state.

Sir M. Visvesvaraya (Diwan, 1912–1918) was an engineer, economist and administrator who became known as the “**Maker of Modern Mysuru**.” He initiated the **Kannambadi Reservoir Project**, strengthened the legislative system, promoted industries such as the **Sandalwood Oil Factory, Mysuru Chrome and Tanning Factory, Government Soap Factory and Bhadravati iron unit**, and established institutions including **Bengaluru Engineering College, Medical School, Agricultural School, Mysuru University, Mysuru Bank and Chamber of Commerce**. **Sir Mirza M. Ismail (Diwan, 1926–1941)** further expanded Mysuru's industrial and irrigation development. He completed the **Kannambadi Project**, commissioned the **Cauvery Upper Canal**, expanded the **Bhadravati Iron Factory with a steel unit**, and established industries including **Mysuru Paper Mills, Government Cement Factory, Mandya**

³¹ [A Handbook of Karnataka](#) Page 96

Sugar Factory, Mysuru Chemical and Fertilizers Factory, Glass and Porcelain Factories, and initiated plans for power generation at Shimsha and Jog and Hindustan Aircrafts.³²

Independence — One language, five Fragments

The **Karnataka Unification movement** developed because Kannada-speaking regions were divided among several administrations, including **Mysuru, Bombay, Madras, Hyderabad and Kodagu**, as well as smaller princely states. This fragmentation created difficulties for Kannadigas, particularly where Kannada education and administration were limited. The **Renaissance** strengthened the demand for unification, and **Dharwad** emerged as the centre of the movement, with **Alur Venkatarao** described as its “brain.” The establishment of the **Karnataka Sahithya Parishat in 1915** provided a forum for Kannada writers and intellectuals, while the **Karnataka State Political Conference at Dharwad in 1920** decided to pursue unification through the Congress organisation. This gave the movement wider political support, followed by the **first Unification Conference at Belagavi in 1924** and subsequent conferences. In **1926**, the Hindustani Sevalal began a signature campaign, which received nearly **36,000 signatures**, and in **1928**, the Jawaharlal Nehru Committee recommended a separate Karnataka Province. After independence, Karnataka remained divided among **five administrations**, leading to continued demands for unification and the formation of the **Karnataka Ekikarana Maha Samiti in 1947**. The Dhar Committee subsequently gave an adverse report, which was opposed at the **Jayapur Congress Session in 1948**; the JVP Committee followed in 1948 but recommended only the creation of Andhra Pradesh. The agitation therefore continued, and after the **Fazl Ali Commission** was appointed in 1953, its recommendations led to the formation of a **linguistically unified Mysuru State on 1 November 1956**, with **S. Nijalingappa as Chief Minister**. The state was later renamed **Karnataka in 1973**.³³

Congress Dominance and Early State Politics, 1952–1972

The first general election was held in 1952, following the adoption of the Constitution in 1950. Congress emerged as the dominant political force in the newly formed Mysore State, and this dominance continued through the early decades of state politics. Important Chief Ministers during this period included K. Chengalaraya Reddy, Kengal Hanumanthaiah and S. Nijalingappa. The reorganisation of Mysore State in 1956 brought together Kannada-speaking areas from different administrative units, creating the political basis for the later Karnataka state.³⁴

Devaraj Urs and Social Transformation, 1972–1977

D. Devaraj Urs, who became Chief Minister in 1972, marked an important phase in Karnataka politics. His government pursued land reforms and policies aimed at improving the position and representation of backward classes. These measures contributed to changes in the state's social and political structure and weakened the earlier dominance of established political groups.³⁵

Political Shift and the Rise of the Janata Party, 1978–1983

The claim that 1977–78 was a Janata Party interlude in Karnataka should be removed. Devaraj Urs continued as Chief Minister after the 1978 Karnataka Assembly election, when Congress won a majority. The major political

³² [A Handbook of Karnataka](#) Page 100

³³ [A Handbook of Karnataka](#) Page 107

³⁴ [A Handbook of Karnataka](#) Page 109

³⁵ [A Handbook of Karnataka](#) Page 111

shift came in 1983, when the Janata Party emerged as the largest party and formed the government under Ramakrishna Hegde. This marked the end of uninterrupted Congress dominance in Karnataka.³⁶

Later Political Competition and the SR Bommai Case

Karnataka subsequently developed a more competitive political system involving the **Congress, Janata formations and later the BJP**. The **S. R. Bommai case**, arising from the dismissal of the Karnataka government in 1989 under Chief Minister S. R. Bommai eventually led to the landmark **1994 Supreme Court judgment** on Article 356 and the limits of the Centre's power to dismiss state governments. This is an important constitutional episode, but it should be treated separately from the earlier Congress-dominance period.

Chief Ministers of the State from 1947



3. Caste Census

The Socio-Economic and Educational Survey, conducted in 2015 and accepted by the state Cabinet in April 2025, has reopened Karnataka's reservation debate. The survey found an Other Backward Classes share of seventy per cent among those enumerated, the largest single social bloc in the count; a

Scheduled Caste population of 1.09 crore; and a Scheduled Tribe population of 42.8 lakh, or roughly seven per cent of those enumerated. A proposed combined OBC and Scheduled Caste/Scheduled Tribe reservation, including Muslims classified under Category 2B, would move from a current 51% to more than 75%, breaking the fifty per cent ceiling set by the Supreme Court in Indra Sawhney. Table 1 sets out the headline community counts, which are the most politically contested rows in the report.³⁷

Bloc	Share	Headcount	Reservation Politics
Lingayat / 3B	11.1%	66.4 lakh	Quota proposed 8% (from 5%)
Vokkaliga / 3A	10.3%	61.7 lakh	Quota proposed 7% (from 4%)
Muslims / 2B	12.6%*	75.3 lakh	Quota proposed 8% (from 4%)
Most backward / 1	—	new 1A + 1B	Nomadic / Kuruba re-stack

Table 1: Headline community shares in the Socio-Economic and Educational Survey. *75.25 lakh of 5.98 crore enumerated persons; some political readings have circulated a figure of 18%. Source: internal PPGF briefing, August 2026, citing the Survey report.

The state's fiscal health

Karnataka's economy recorded strong real GSDP growth of 8.1 per cent at constant prices in 2025–26, which surpassed the national growth rate of 7.4 per cent for the same period. This performance was supported by broad-based sectoral growth and reflects the State's diversified and stable growth pattern. For 2026–27, the revenue deficit is estimated at Rs.22,957 crore. The fiscal deficit is estimated at Rs.97,449 crore, which is 2.95% of GSDP, and total liabilities at the end of the year are estimated at Rs.8,24,389 crore, amounting to 24.94% of GSDP. Both the fiscal deficit and total liabilities are within the limits prescribed under the Karnataka Fiscal Responsibility Act, this reflects the State's continued commitment to responsible fiscal management. Despite fiscal pressures arising from GST rate rationalisation and reduced tax devolution, Karnataka has responsibly and resolutely adhered to fiscal discipline over the past three years. In the fourth year as well, in accordance with the provisions of the Karnataka Fiscal Responsibility Act, the State has contained the fiscal deficit within 3 per cent of GSDP and total liabilities within 25 per cent of GSDP, thereby reaffirming the State's commitment to fiscal prudence and long-term fiscal sustainability. For 2026–27, the revenue deficit is estimated at Rs.22,957 crore. The fiscal deficit is estimated at Rs.97,449 crore, which is 2.95% of GSDP, and total liabilities at the end of the year are estimated at Rs.8,24,389 crore, amounting to 24.94% of GSDP. For the year 2025–26, the revised estimate of total receipts is Rs.3,93,572 crore. Revenue receipts are estimated at Rs.2,77,402 crore, which include State's own tax revenue of Rs.1,93,100 crore, non-tax revenue of Rs.17,500 crore, and receipts from the Government of India amounting to Rs.66,802 crore. Within these constraints on revenue availability, the State has carefully prioritised its expenditure to balance growth, welfare, and fiscal discipline. The State has stood by its commitments on social protection and welfare. Since the introduction of the Government's guarantee

³⁷PPGF, "Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance", internal briefing, August 2026, slide 11.

schemes, an amount of Rs.1,21,598 crore has been spent up to February 2026, which demonstrates that the Government has honoured its assurances while it maintains fiscal prudence.³⁸

Fiscal Stress Points

Karnataka faces fiscal pressures arising from unreleased Central grants, reduced Central support, and delays in fund releases. The ₹5,495 crore special grant and ₹6,000 crore state-specific grants recommended by the 15th Finance Commission remain unreleased. The Budget also identifies reduced Central shares in Centrally Sponsored Schemes and allocation concerns in Central Sector schemes as additional pressures on the State exchequer. Under the Jal Jeevan Mission, ₹19,102 crore of the approved Central share remains to be released, while the State has already released ₹27,098 crore and provided an additional ₹15,500 crore during 2025–26. Alongside these funding constraints, the Budget highlights structural challenges to State own-tax revenues, making predictable and fair tax devolution from the Union increasingly important for Karnataka's finances.³⁹

Flagship Policies: The Five Guarantees

Karnataka's five Guarantee Schemes include **Gruha Lakshmi**, **Gruha Jyothi**, **Anna Bhagya**, **Shakti** and **Yuva Nidhi**. Under **Gruha Lakshmi**, ₹62,345 crore has been paid to eligible beneficiaries, with **1.24 crore beneficiaries** receiving financial assistance; ₹28,608 crore has been earmarked for 2026–27. **Gruha Jyothi** has enrolled **1.74 crore consumers**, with ₹28,000 crore spent over the last three years and ₹10,578 crore allocated for 2026–27. Under **Anna Bhagya**, an additional **5 kg of rice per month** has been distributed to **4.54 crore beneficiaries**, with ₹17,167 crore spent over the last three years; for 2026–27, this provision is being replaced by an **Indira Food Kit**. **Shakti** has recorded **684 crore women-beneficiary trips**, with ₹5,300 crore allocated for 2026–27. Under **Yuva Nidhi**, ₹913 crore in unemployment allowance has been transferred to **3,08,267 eligible beneficiaries** through direct cash transfers.⁴⁰

Social and Health Development Profile of Karnataka

Karnataka records relatively high levels of household access to basic services and health infrastructure, alongside persistent nutritional and non-communicable disease challenges. According to **NFHS-6 (2023–24)**, **99.7% of households had electricity**, **97.3% had access to an improved drinking-water source** and **96.3% used improved sanitation facilities**. Coverage under a health-insurance or financing scheme was **63.3%**, while **98.6% of households reported having a bank or post-office account**.

Educational and digital indicators also show progress, although substantial gender and rural–urban differences remain. Among adults aged 15–49, **57.6% of women and 63.0% of men had completed 10 or more years of schooling**. Internet use was reported by **57.9% of women and 84.3% of men**, with a marked urban–rural gap.

³⁸ [Karnataka State Budget 2026-27](#)

³⁹ [Karnataka State Budget 2026-27](#)

⁴⁰ [Karnataka State Budget 2026-27](#)

Maternal and child health indicators remain comparatively strong. **82.4% of mothers received antenatal care in the first trimester**, while **96.3% received at least four antenatal check-ups**. Institutional births accounted for **98.7% of deliveries**, and **90.2% of children aged 12–23 months were fully vaccinated** based on vaccination cards or mothers' recall.

However, **child nutrition remains a significant development concern**. Among children under five, **48.3% were stunted**, **19.7% were wasted**, **4.7% were severely wasted** and **27.8% were underweight**. Only **19.7% of children aged 6–23 months received an adequate diet**, indicating continuing challenges in child nutrition despite relatively strong healthcare coverage.

Karnataka is simultaneously experiencing a growing burden of **overweight, elevated blood sugar and hypertension**. Among adults aged 15–49, **41.2% of women and 36.4% of men were overweight or obese**. Among adults aged 15 years and above, elevated blood sugar or medication use was reported for **22.3% of women and 26.1% of men**, while elevated blood pressure or medication use was reported for **25.1% of women and 28.2% of men**.

Indicators of **women's empowerment and financial/digital inclusion** are relatively strong. **89.2% of currently married women participated in the three specified household decisions**, **94.7% had a bank or savings account that they themselves used**, and **72.4% had a mobile phone that they themselves used**. Among women aged 15–24, **84.1% used hygienic methods of menstrual protection**.

Overall, NFHS-6 presents Karnataka as a State with **high household-service coverage, strong institutional healthcare access, high immunisation and substantial financial and digital inclusion, but continuing challenges in child nutrition and the rising burden of overweight, high blood sugar and hypertension**. The persistent urban–rural differences in education, internet access, health and nutrition remain important for assessing the State's development trajectory.⁴¹

Costs & Critiques of the Guarantees

Karnataka's five Guarantee Schemes represent a substantial and recurring fiscal commitment, generating both fiscal concerns and measurable social benefits. According to the Comptroller and Auditor General of India (CAG), expenditure on the five Guarantee Schemes amounted to **₹52,526 crore in 2024–25**, equivalent to approximately **19% of the State's Revenue Expenditure**. The CAG notes that the increase in subsidies was mainly driven by the five Guarantee Schemes and that their recurring costs placed pressure on the State's fiscal position. Revenue growth was insufficient to fully absorb these costs, resulting in greater reliance on borrowing to finance the schemes and the revenue deficit.

The **universal design** of the schemes is another area of concern. The CAG characterises the five Guarantees as universal in nature and highlights the need to consider better targeting or rationalisation to reduce fiscal pressure. Rising subsidy expenditure has also affected the State's fiscal space. The CAG reports that increased

⁴¹ [National Family Health Survey 6](#)

interest payments and debt-servicing obligations have constrained resources available for development and could place pressure on future capital expenditure and other welfare programmes.

However, the fiscal costs need to be considered alongside the schemes' reported social outcomes. The CAG records benefits including **greater mobility for women under Shakti, additional financial liquidity through Gruha Lakshmi, improved food security through Anna Bhagya and household savings associated with Gruha Jyothi.**⁴² A separate Karnataka-specific study covering approximately **26,000 women** reported that female labour-force participation increased from **25.3% to 30.2%** in the first year of Shakti; 57% of respondents reported improved access to jobs and 49% reported increased community participation.⁴³

Governance Structure of Karnataka

Karnataka operates through a **parliamentary system of state government**, combining the State Executive, a bicameral Legislature and decentralised local governance. The **Governor** serves as the constitutional head of the State, while executive authority is exercised through the elected government headed by the **Chief Minister and Council of Ministers**. The Council of Ministers is responsible for different departments and for implementing policies and programmes approved by the government.

The **Karnataka Legislature is bicameral**, comprising the **Legislative Assembly (224 elected members)** and the **Legislative Council (75 members)**. The Legislature performs law-making, budgetary and oversight functions. The first sitting of the reorganised State's Assembly was held at **Vidhana Soudha in Bengaluru in 1956**, which remains the principal seat of the State Legislature.

Governance is further decentralised through **Panchayati Raj Institutions** in rural areas. Under the Karnataka Gram Swaraj and Panchayat Raj framework, local rural governance operates through **Gram Panchayats, Taluk Panchayats and Zilla Panchayats**. Urban areas are administered through Urban Local Bodies, including municipal corporations and municipalities.

Thus, Karnataka's governance structure links **constitutional leadership through the Governor, elected executive authority through the Chief Minister and Council of Ministers, legislative oversight through the two Houses of the State Legislature, and decentralised administration through rural and urban local governments**. This multi-level structure enables policy formulation at the State level while providing institutional mechanisms for local planning, administration and service delivery.

Elections: Similarities and Divergence

Karnataka's electoral politics is strongly shaped by **caste coalitions, welfare, regional interests and ideological positioning**. The three major parties, Congress, BJP and JD(S), have all engaged in social coalition-building, particularly around the politically influential **Lingayat and Vokkaliga communities**. In the 2023 Assembly election, these two communities accounted for a large share of the candidates fielded by all three parties, demonstrating their continuing electoral importance.

⁴² [Report of the Comptroller and Auditor General of India on State Finances for the year 2024-25](#)

⁴³ [Gender, Welfare, and Mobility Azim Premji University](#)

Similarities: All three parties use **social engineering** to build electoral coalitions across dominant castes, OBCs, Dalits, minorities and other communities. Welfare has also become an important component of electoral competition, although the parties differ substantially in the design and political framing of their welfare policies. The 2023 election demonstrated that caste loyalties are not completely fixed: Congress made significant gains in both Lingayat- and Vokkaliga-dominated constituencies, while BJP and JD(S) continued to rely on their respective historical social bases.

Congress: Congress has traditionally used the **AHINDA framework**—*Alpasankhyata* (minorities), *Hindulida Vargagalu* (backward classes) and *Dalitaru* (Dalits)—particularly associated with Siddaramaiah’s social-justice politics. In 2023, the party combined this broader social coalition with its emphasis on welfare and guarantees. Congress also expanded into traditionally Vokkaliga-dominated areas, demonstrating that its electoral strategy is not restricted to the AHINDA coalition.

BJP: The BJP has historically maintained a strong electoral relationship with **Lingayat voters**, particularly through the political influence of B.S. Yediyurappa. Its Karnataka strategy also combines **Hindutva and nationalism** with efforts to broaden its social base. The party has traditionally performed strongly in parts of **coastal Karnataka and urban constituencies**, although its support is not confined to these regions.

JD(S): JD(S) has historically been associated with the **Vokkaliga community and the Old Mysuru region**, with the political legacy of the Deve Gowda family playing a central role. However, its electoral position has weakened considerably. It won **19 seats in the 2023 Assembly election**, compared with 37 in 2018, and lost substantial ground in Vokkaliga-dominated constituencies. Its subsequent alliance with the BJP has further altered Karnataka’s electoral alignments.

Karnataka Assembly Election 2028

The 2028 Karnataka Assembly election is likely to be shaped by the interaction of **incumbency, welfare delivery, caste and social-justice politics, and the BJP–JD(S) alliance**. The political context has changed significantly since the 2023 Assembly election, particularly following the change in Congress leadership in 2026 and the BJP–JD(S) decision to strengthen coordination ahead of the 2028 election.

Incumbency and Congress: Congress enters the 2028 contest as the incumbent government, but the leadership transition from Siddaramaiah to **D.K. Shivakumar in 2026** has altered the political landscape. The election will test whether Congress can retain the coalition that brought it to power in 2023 while managing the effects of incumbency and demonstrating continuity in governance and welfare delivery.

BJP–JD(S) alliance: The BJP and JD(S) are preparing to contest the 2028 election together and have decided to establish a coordination committee. The alliance seeks to combine the BJP’s organisational and regional strengths with JD(S)’s historical Vokkaliga base. However, recent disagreements and cross-voting indicate that **vote transfer and seat-sharing remain important challenges** for the alliance.

Guarantee Schemes: The five Guarantee Schemes are likely to remain an important electoral and policy issue. Their political significance will depend on whether voters continue to perceive tangible benefits from the

schemes while the government manages their recurring fiscal costs. The central electoral question will therefore be the balance between **welfare delivery and fiscal sustainability**, rather than welfare popularity alone.

Caste and social-justice politics: Caste-based mobilisation is likely to remain significant, particularly around **Lingayat, Vokkaliga, OBC, Dalit and minority constituencies**. The Congress government's continued emphasis on the socio-economic survey and caste-based social-justice agenda could influence reservation and resource-allocation debates. However, the eventual electoral impact of these issues cannot yet be predicted.

Regional competition: Karnataka's electoral geography remains differentiated. The BJP has historically been strong in **coastal Karnataka, Bengaluru and parts of North Karnataka**, while JD(S) has traditionally had greater influence in **Old Mysuru**. Congress has a broader statewide presence and has recently sought to strengthen its position among both AHINDA groups and Vokkaligas. These regional patterns are not fixed and may change by 2028.

Kalyana Karnataka comprises **Bidar, Kalaburagi, Yadgir, Koppal, Raichur, Ballari and Vijayanagara** and remains one of Karnataka's principal regional-development policy areas. **Article 371J**, inserted through the 98th Constitutional Amendment in 2012, provides special provisions for the region, including a separate development board, equitable allocation of development funds and enhanced opportunities in education and public employment.

The **Kalyana Karnataka Region Development Board (KKRDB)** implements district-wise action plans across the seven districts. However, the CAG has found that the region continues to lag behind other parts of Karnataka on several socio-economic indicators, highlighting weaknesses in outcome-oriented planning and monitoring. The central policy question is therefore not merely the **scale of expenditure**, but whether Article 371J and KKRDB interventions translate into sustained improvements in **education, health, infrastructure, employment and regional productivity**.

Regional Deep-Dive: Bombay Karnataka

Bombay Karnataka is a historical-regional designation for north-western Karnataka, reflecting its former association with the **Bombay Presidency and Bombay State**. Under the **States Reorganisation Act, 1956**, Belgaum, Bijapur and Dharwar districts, among others, were transferred from Bombay State to the newly constituted Mysore State. The term is now a **historical and regional classification rather than an administrative division**.

The region is commonly associated with **Belagavi, Dharwad, Vijayapura, Bagalkot, Gadag and Haveri**. It has a strong **Veerashaiva-Lingayat social and political presence**, which has historically influenced political mobilisation and leadership in North Karnataka. However, a specific **Lingayat-majority** claim should be avoided because contemporary official district-level caste data do not establish such a demographic majority.

Belagavi gives the region an additional political significance because of the longstanding **Maharashtra–Karnataka border dispute**, which emerged following the linguistic reorganisation of states in 1956. The **Maharashtra Ekikaran Samiti (MES)** has historically advocated the incorporation of Belagavi and

other Marathi-speaking areas into Maharashtra. The **Mahajan Commission**, constituted by the Union Government, submitted its report in 1967, but the territorial dispute remains unresolved.

The region also reflects a distinct **North Karnataka identity**, reinforced by concerns over regional development disparities. The **D.M. Nanjundappa Committee** examined intra-state regional imbalances, while subsequent government programmes have sought to address backwardness through targeted investment. Consequently, Bombay Karnataka represents an important intersection of **historical identity, community politics, linguistic contestation and regional-development concerns**.

Regional Deep-Dive: Bombay Karnataka — Politics

Bombay Karnataka, commonly referred to in contemporary political analysis as **Kittur Karnataka/Mumbai-Karnataka**, has historically been an important **BJP electoral region**, partly because of its concentration of Lingayat voters and the party's long-standing political organisation in North Karnataka. However, the region should not be treated as a permanent BJP stronghold. The **2023 Assembly election significantly changed the electoral balance**: in the 50-seat Mumbai-Karnataka classification used by contemporary election analysis, Congress won **33 seats**, compared with **16 for BJP and 1 for JD(S)**. In 2018, BJP had won 33 seats in the same regional classification.

The region has produced prominent political leaders, including **Jagadish Shettar**, a senior Lingayat leader from the Hubballi-Dharwad area, and **Pralhad Joshi**, who represents Dharwad in the Lok Sabha and has been a prominent BJP leader from the region. Shettar's political career illustrates the fluidity of regional politics: after briefly joining Congress before the 2023 Assembly election, he subsequently returned to BJP and won the **Belagavi Lok Sabha seat in 2024**.

Belagavi adds a distinctive linguistic and territorial dimension to the region's politics. The **Maharashtra Ekikaran Samiti (MES)** has historically campaigned for the incorporation of Marathi-speaking areas of Karnataka into Maharashtra. The Maharashtra–Karnataka border dispute remains unresolved; the Union Government's official record notes the **Mahajan Commission's 1967 report** and the pending Supreme Court proceedings initiated by Maharashtra.

The 2023 election therefore demonstrates that Bombay Karnataka is better understood as a **historically BJP-influenced but electorally competitive region**. Congress's substantial gains show that Lingayat political preferences are not fixed and that broader factors—including candidate selection, welfare politics, leadership, local issues and anti-incumbency—can reshape the region's electoral map.

Image: Ref⁴⁴

Mayurasharma founded the Kadamba dynasty at Banavasi around 345 CE, often read as the first native Kannada kingdom. The Halmidi inscription of around 450 CE brought Kannada into stone and, by extension, into the modern historical syllabus. The Western Ganga dynasty, ruling from Talakad between roughly 350 and 1000 CE, left as its most enduring public work the Gomateshwara monolith at Shravanabelagola, dated to around 983 CE. Every later political claim in Karnataka's history — Rashtrakuta, Vijayanagara, and even the 1973 renaming — traces back to this first inscriptional state.⁴⁵

B. Imperial Era

Three successive dynasties gave Karnataka its imperial architectural and literary grammar. The Badami Chalukyas, ruling first from Badami and later Kalyani, treated temple form as statecraft, with the Aihole-Badami-Pattadakal complex forming a single political landscape. The Rashtrakutas, ruling from Manyakheta, produced the Kavirajamarga around 850 CE, the first extant work of Kannada poetics and a court claim to a distinct literary language. The Hoysalas, through their temples at Belur, Halebidu and Somanathapura, built a successor state whose soapstone craftsmanship became, a millennium later, a UNESCO World Heritage file.⁴⁶

C. Vijayanagara

The Vijayanagara empire, from 1336 to 1565, made Hampi one of the early-modern world's large cities, reaching its schoolbook peak under Krishna Deva Raya. The Battle of Talikota in 1565 sacked the metropolis and shifted the political centre of Kannada country south toward Mysore. In 1537, Kempe Gowda I, a

⁴⁴ [A Handbook of Karnataka](#) Page 125

⁴⁵ PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 17.

⁴⁶ PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 18.

Vijayanagara feudatory, founded Bengaluru; the mud fort he established became, four centuries later, the state's fiscal engine.⁴⁷

D. Mysore Sultanate

Hyder Ali moved from military commander to de facto ruler of Mysore, building a standing army and a spy network and administering a state that taxed more efficiently than the Wodeyars it displaced. His son Tipu Sultan developed rocket artillery, state trading and sericulture while confronting the East India Company; he remains a contested historical figure, claimed by both modernisers and martyrs, with the argument itself now a live political question. The fall of Srirangapatna in 1799 restored Mysore to a child Wodeyar under a subsidiary alliance, beginning the princely nineteenth century. Tipu Sultan remains a live symbol in contemporary Karnataka, generating textbook disputes, statue politics and a broadly north-south divide in how the state remembers Islamicate power.⁴⁸

E. Colonial Era

The Kannada-speaking country was never administered as a single colonial unit. Princely Mysore, under British paramountcy from 1881 following the Rendition, developed irrigation, industry and bureaucratic modernism under a succession of Dewans, including Sheshadri Iyer, Sir M. Visvesvaraya and Mirza Ismail. Bombay Karnataka, comprising Belagavi, Dharwad, Uttara Kannada and Vijayapura, developed under a different land-revenue system and public sphere. Hyderabad Karnataka, comprising Kalaburagi, Bidar, Raichur, Koppal, Yadgir and parts of Ballari, was administered under the Nizam's state, a legacy that later produced the Article 371J special status. Madras Karnataka, comprising Dakshina Kannada and Kollegal, developed coastal and plantation links into the Tamil-speaking presidency. Sir M. Visvesvaraya's tenure, marked by the Krishnaraja Sagara dam and the Bhadravati iron works, set the twentieth-century template of industrialise-or-perish development thinking that continues to inform Karnataka's economic policy.⁴⁹

F. Political Era 1 – Unification (1947–1956)

Between 1947 and 1950, Mysore state acceded to the Indian Union as a princely core, while Kannada-speaking fragments remained divided across Bombay, Madras and Hyderabad states. In 1953, the creation of Andhra state moved Bellary's Kannada-speaking taluks into Mysore, an early instance of linguistic boundary revision. On 1 November 1956, the States Reorganisation Act created the united Mysore State, establishing close to the state's present outline. The settlement was incomplete: Belagavi remained a contested border with Maharashtra, and the Kasargod region was allotted to Kerala, leaving the map a settlement rather than a full consensus.⁵⁰

G. Political Era 2 – Consolidation (1956–1970s)

Between the mid-1950s and the 1970s, Bengaluru became a Union public-sector workshop through Hindustan Aeronautics Limited, Bharat Electronics Limited, Indian Telephone Industries, Bharat Earth Movers Limited and Hindustan Machine Tools, making the city a strategic industrial centre before it became a software centre. Hindustan Aeronautics and the defence-industrial belt established Bengaluru's strategic character; Indian Telephone Industries and Bharat Electronics preceded private information-technology investment by a

⁴⁷PPGF, "Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance", internal briefing, August 2026, slide 19.

⁴⁸PPGF, "Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance", internal briefing, August 2026, slide 20.

⁴⁹PPGF, "Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance", internal briefing, August 2026, slide 21.

⁵⁰PPGF, "Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance", internal briefing, August 2026, slide 22.

generation. This period coincided with Congress party dominance, a modernising state bureaucracy, and the 1973 renaming of the state, linking identity politics and industrial policy in the same decade. The public-sector cluster of this era is the direct institutional precondition for the later Infosys-led software story; Karnataka's Silicon Valley branding rests on this public foundation.⁵¹

H. Political Era 3 – Social Engineering (1973–1980s)

Chief Minister Shri D. Devaraj Urs used land reform and coalition-building as instruments of statecraft. The 1974 land reforms broke absentee landlordism in Old Mysore more thoroughly than in most Indian states, creating a new rural middle class and a new Congress political base. Urs assembled the AHINDA coalition of minorities, backward classes and Dalits against the established dominance of the Lingayat and Vokkaliga communities in the ministry; Dr Siddaramaiah later inherited this coalition's underlying grammar rather than merely its slogan. The 1973 renaming and the subsequent backward-class commissions of this period made caste an explicit instrument of cabinet design rather than only a matter of social justice policy.⁵²

I. Political Era 4 – Liberalisation (1990s–Present)

From the 1990s, Karnataka built a Silicon Valley brand through liberalisation and the growth of Infosys and Wipro, followed by the wave of Global Capability Centres. During the term of Chief Minister S.M. Krishna, Bengaluru was marketed through Singapore-style rhetoric, an international airport and elevated road infrastructure, treating a world-class capital city as a Chief Ministerial project. Software exports became the state's fiscal cushion and calling card. Politically, this era saw the Bharatiya Janata Party establish its southern beachhead in 2008, the Janata Dal (Secular) function as a recurring kingmaker, and the Congress party return to power on the strength of its welfare guarantees in 2023 — with the Silicon Valley brand outlasting successive governments. The underlying bargain of this era remains unresolved: a rich capital city, a comparatively poorer north, and a politics that markets Bengaluru's fiscal surplus as statewide welfare.⁵³

Analytical Takeaways – Part III

1. Karnataka's contemporary political identity rests on a continuous thread from the Halmidi inscription through the 1956 unification to the 1973 renaming; any campaign narrative built on Kannada identity draws on thirteen centuries of continuous claim-making, not a recent construction.
2. The Bengaluru public-sector cluster of the 1950s-70s is the direct institutional ancestor of the present-day IT and Global Capability Centre economy; Government messaging on Bengaluru's rise should credit this history rather than presenting the software boom as a standalone 1990s event.
3. The AHINDA coalition, first assembled by Shri Devaraj Urs in the 1970s, remains the organisational template that Dr Siddaramaiah used in 2023; any assessment of Congress strategy in Karnataka should treat this as a fifty-year continuity, not a personal innovation.
4. The unresolved Belagavi border and the incomplete 1956 settlement remain live political instruments; either major party can and does reopen these questions when a north-Karnataka mobilisation is required.

⁵¹PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 23.

⁵²PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 24.

⁵³PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 25.

VI. Part IV – Governance

A. Administrative Structure

Karnataka's constitutional executive runs through Raj Bhavan, presently headed by Governor Shri Thaawarchand Gehlot, and the political executive under Chief Minister Shri D.K. Shivakumar, in office from 3 June 2026, supported by the Cabinet and the Chief Secretary. The state is divided into four revenue divisions — Bengaluru, Mysuru, Belagavi and Kalaburagi — and 31 districts, each headed by a Deputy Commissioner functioning as the Union's representative at the district level. Below the district, the administrative chain runs through Taluk, Hobli and Village levels, where the revenue administration continues to outrank many governance reforms in practical importance. Vidhana Soudha remains the working seat of this structure.⁵⁴

B. e-Governance Models

Karnataka computerised significant parts of state administration before most Indian states had built comparable digital systems, structured around a six-platform stack referred to internally as the 6-I model. Bhoomi digitised land-record mutation, reducing the village accountant's earlier monopoly while creating new digital-access gatekeepers. Khajane II serves as the state's payment spine, clearing every salary, pension and welfare-scheme payment. Kaveri functions as the property-registration database and a fiscal pillar through stamp duty collection. Seva Sindhu operates as the unified citizen portal layered on top of individual department systems. FRUITS and the K-GIS platform maintain the farmer registry and the spatial data layer underlying most new welfare schemes. Panchatantra 2.0 digitises gram panchayat accounting and service delivery.⁵⁵

C. Transparency and Accountability

The Sakala Mission, introduced in 2011, establishes statutory time limits for notified government services with compensation for delay; the mechanism has travelled well as an idea, though the underlying administrative culture of delay has not always followed. Citizen charters, published on an ongoing basis by every department, function as a floor commitment but remain a weak enforcement tool without Sakala's statutory backing. A statewide e-Procurement system has moved tenders onto a single digital platform, though collusion has adapted to the portal rather than disappearing. The Right to Information Act and the Lokayukta institution together represent a long institutional memory of anti-corruption mechanisms, and, at points, of captured inquiries.⁵⁶

D. Panchayati Raj System

Karnataka was an early laboratory for Panchayati Raj, from the Abdul Nazir Sab reforms through to the present Panchatantra digital platform, and operates a three-tier structure. The Gram Panchayat, at the village level, is the only tier that continues to hold elections with reasonable regularity, and the Seventy-third Constitutional Amendment took earlier practical effect here than in many states. The Taluk Panchayat, at the block level, functions as a comparatively neglected middle tier through which schemes pass with thinner political engagement and constrained administrative capacity. The Zilla Panchayat, at the district level, is elected but operates in the shadow of the Deputy Commissioner, creating a persistent tension between development funds and the revenue establishment. Panchatantra 2.0 provides the digital twin of this structure for accounts, works

⁵⁴PPGF, "Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance", internal briefing, August 2026, slide 26.

⁵⁵PPGF, "Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance", internal briefing, August 2026, slide 27.

⁵⁶PPGF, "Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance", internal briefing, August 2026, slide 28.

and certificates, though the underlying governance question is whether the gram sabha can still hold a contractor accountable once the party and the engineer are already aligned.⁵⁷

E. Urban Self-Governance

Karnataka's municipal law provides a complete organisational ladder — municipal corporations, city municipal councils and town panchayats — but municipal elections have not kept pace with this legal architecture. The AMRUT and Smart Cities missions have brought capital expenditure with visible branding to Hubballi-Dharwad, Belagavi, Shivamogga, Tumakuru, Mangaluru and Bengaluru, though operational responsibility often remains with structurally weak urban local bodies. The 2024–25 Greater Bengaluru Governance Act split the Bruhat Bengaluru Mahanagara Palike into five corporations under a Greater Bengaluru Authority, a change that can be read either as reform or as a further postponement of the municipal vote. Where the Seventy-third Amendment produced a functioning rural election culture in Karnataka, the Seventy-fourth Amendment has instead produced administrator-run cities — a gap that is now the subject of active constitutional litigation.⁵⁸

F. Social Registry and Direct Benefit Transfer

Kutumba, the state's resident data hub, links ration cards, Aadhaar, caste, income and household-member data into a single social registry, making the five welfare guarantees introduced in 2023 function in practice as structured queries against this database. The system operates through five stages: enumeration of the household as the unit of record rather than the individual scheme form; deduplication, collapsing Aadhaar, ration, student and farmer identity numbers; eligibility determination based on income, gender, land-holding and employment flags; direct benefit transfer or in-kind delivery, covering Gruha Lakshmi payments to women, Gruha Jyoti electricity-meter benefits, and rice entitlements to the ration card; and roll audit. The next major political contest around this system concerns exclusion errors on one side and ghost inclusion on the other.⁵⁹

Analytical Takeaways – Part IV

1. Karnataka's digital-governance stack — Bhoomi, Khajane, Kaveri and Kutumba — is genuinely ahead of most Indian states and is the operational precondition that makes the five welfare guarantees administratively deliverable; any critique of guarantee spending should distinguish fiscal sustainability from delivery-mechanism quality, which is strong.
2. The Seventy-third Amendment has functioned as intended in Karnataka; the Seventy-fourth has not. The Greater Bengaluru Governance Act is best read as an attempt to manage, rather than resolve, this asymmetry, and the pending constitutional challenge is a material near-term political and administrative risk.
3. Sakala and e-Procurement have measurably reduced petty transactional corruption while shifting rent-seeking to more sophisticated points in the system; digital reform in Karnataka has changed the form of corruption more than its incidence.

⁵⁷PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 29.

⁵⁸PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 30.

⁵⁹PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 31.

4. The Zilla Panchayat-Deputy Commissioner tension is a structural, not incidental, feature of Karnataka's governance architecture and will continue to constrain the effectiveness of any district-level scheme regardless of which party is in office.

VII. Part V – Social Delivery

A. Health Infrastructure

Karnataka operates a dual health system with strong tertiary institutions but a thinner rural mesh. Community health centres and Primary Health Centres, along with sub-centres, carry the first-mile burden of immunisation, maternal and child health, and non-communicable disease screening; staffing rather than physical infrastructure is the binding constraint in the north-east of the state. Taluk and district hospitals function as the workhorse referral tier, though unofficial referral leakage toward Bengaluru effectively forms part of the system's design. Tertiary and autonomous institutions — the National Institute of Mental Health and Neurosciences, Kidwai Memorial Institute of Oncology, Jayadeva Institute of Cardiology, and Victoria and Bowring hospitals, alongside medical college hospitals — carry a national reputation while remaining part of the state cadre. A substantial private Bengaluru medical-tourism and insurance market simultaneously draws doctors away from the public roster, producing what is, in effect, two health systems sharing one pin code.⁶⁰

B. Health Data

The fifth National Family Health Survey, conducted in 2019–21, places Karnataka ahead of the Hindi-belt states though not yet at a southern peer level with Kerala. Table 2 sets out the headline indicators.⁶¹

Indicator	Value	Interpretation
Total fertility rate	1.7	Below replacement; demographic transition complete
Infant mortality rate	25 per 1,000	Down from NFHS-4, still above Kerala and Tamil Nadu
Institutional births	97%	Delivery point is largely a facility; quality is the next metric
Full immunisation (12–23 months)	84%	High but not universal
Stunting, under-5	35%	The stubborn nutrition number
Anaemia, women 15–49	48%	A silent epidemic beside the information-technology skyline

Table 2: National Family Health Survey-5 (2019–21) headline indicators for Karnataka. Source: internal PPGF briefing, August 2026, citing NFHS-5.

C. Health Schemes

Karnataka runs a layered health-insurance architecture on top of the national Ayushman Bharat framework. Ayushman Bharat-Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana provides the national floor of secondary and tertiary cover for households identified under the Socio-Economic Caste Census; the brand is national, but hospital empanelment remains a state function. The state has folded its own scheme into a common Arogya Karnataka-AB-ArK card, reducing duplication while creating a politics around scheme branding. Yeshasvini, a cooperative-era farmer health-insurance design that predates Ayushman Bharat, continues to explain a degree of rural trust in the system. Formal-sector workers and the Bengaluru middle class largely access coverage through

⁶⁰PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 32.

⁶¹PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 33.

the Employees' State Insurance scheme, the Central Government Health Scheme, or private insurance, and rarely enter the public ward system if they can avoid it. Diagnostics, cancer drugs and last-mile Primary Health Centre costs remain the areas where households continue to pay out of pocket.⁶²

D. Education Profile

Karnataka's education profile is best described as a high peak with an uneven plain. The Indian Institute of Science, the Indian Institute of Management Bangalore and the National Law School of India University sit at one end as national institutions that, in effect, teach the country. Literacy in Dakshina Kannada stood at 88.6% in the 2011 Census, against 51.8% in Yadgir, a district in Kalyana Karnataka, illustrating the scale of the state's internal disparity; the state's male literacy rate was 82.5% against a female rate of 68.1%. The Unified District Information System for Education shows an extensive government-school network alongside a rapid shift toward private schooling in towns, though rising enrolment has not translated into commensurate learning outcomes on the National Achievement Survey or the Annual Status of Education Report. Higher education combines state universities with a dense engineering-college belt around Bengaluru, Mysuru and Hubballi, with quality variance across this belt remaining a persistent concern. The choice between Kannada-medium and English-medium instruction continues to function as a proxy for a broader class debate.⁶³

E. Education Schemes

Karnataka's schooling welfare stack includes mid-day meals, uniforms, bicycle and laptop distribution cycles, and the Kasturba Gandhi Balika Vidyalaya scheme for girls, forming a conventional southern-state welfare kit. Vidyasiri and other post-matric hostel and scholarship schemes for Scheduled Caste, Scheduled Tribe and Other Backward Class students remain a significant, if quiet, social-mobility mechanism, and a recurring point of cabinet-level caste negotiation. Skill development, Industrial Training Institutes and the KEONICS network aim to capture Global Capability Centre and Electronics System Design and Manufacturing hiring outside Bengaluru, with placement rather than enrolment as the relevant metric. State universities face tight fee and grant conditions, with private deemed universities absorbing much of the growing middle-class demand for higher education. Free bus travel for women, introduced under the Shakti scheme in 2023, and a new student-pass initiative under Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar in 2026, extend the welfare architecture into daily mobility. The principal fiscal risk in this area is that guarantee-era revenue stress shows up first as delayed grants to colleges and unpaid honoraria for guest teachers.⁶⁴

Analytical Takeaways – Part V

1. Karnataka's health and education outcomes confirm a consistent state pattern: national-quality peaks (IISc, NIMHANS) coexist with district-level outcomes closer to lower-income states, concentrated overwhelmingly in Kalyana Karnataka.
2. Anaemia among women of reproductive age at 48% and under-five stunting at 35% are the two NFHS-5 indicators most likely to embarrass a Government that markets itself on IT-sector modernity; a targeted nutrition push in these two indicators would carry disproportionate reputational as well as public-health value.

⁶²PPGF, "Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance", internal briefing, August 2026, slide 34.

⁶³PPGF, "Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance", internal briefing, August 2026, slide 35.

⁶⁴PPGF, "Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance", internal briefing, August 2026, slide 36.

3. The gap between Dakshina Kannada and Yadgir literacy is not a data artefact but a structural governance finding, reinforcing the case for sustained, ring-fenced funding under Article 371J rather than annual discretionary allocation.
4. Fiscal stress from the welfare guarantees is already visible in delayed higher-education grants and guest-teacher payments; this is an early-warning indicator worth tracking ahead of any broader assessment of guarantee sustainability.

VIII. Part VI – Infrastructure

A. Road Infrastructure

Karnataka's National Highway network exceeds 8,191 kilometres, and access-controlled corridors are increasingly the state's live infrastructure politics. The Bengaluru-Mysuru access-controlled expressway has materially compressed travel time and reshaped the towns along its ribbon. The state's highway network ties together the Golden Quadrilateral, the North-South corridor, and the Bengaluru-Mysuru expressway, and feeds a growing debate over the Peripheral Ring Road and the Satellite Town Ring Road around the capital, where every delay functions as a congestion tax on Gross State Domestic Product. State Highway and Major District Road quality continues to determine, in practical terms, whether a given taluk is genuinely accessible.⁶⁵

B. Rail and Aviation

The South Western Railway, headquartered in Hubballi, represents both a political win for north Karnataka and a genuine operating corridor linking Bengaluru, Hubballi, Hosapete and Mysuru on a daily basis, though freight movement — particularly iron ore and containers — still awaits a dedicated logistics corridor out of the mining belt. Kempegowda International Airport functions as a second city in its own right, with two terminals, a growing catchment area, and ongoing land-acquisition politics in Devanahalli. Regional aviation under the UDAN scheme, combined with state support, now connects Mangaluru, Hubballi, Belagavi, Mysuru, Kalaburagi, Bidar and Shivamogga. Bengaluru's suburban and commuter rail system remains a promise alongside an already-operating Metro spine, and a second Bengaluru airport, along with an east-west rail line across the Ghats, remain live long-term debates.⁶⁶

C. Maritime Logistics

New Mangalore Port functions as Karnataka's only genuine all-weather major maritime gateway, handling crude oil, petroleum products, coal, fertiliser and containers. The state's 320-kilometre coastline, running from Karwar to Mangaluru, is otherwise served by an extensive network of fishing harbours that function as a parallel port system. Karwar and Belekeri combine a naval presence and an iron-ore trading history with more limited commercial ambitions. Karnataka has no major navigable inland river, so logistics beyond the coast run on road and rail rather than riverine transport.⁶⁷

D. Energy Sector

Karnataka operates a renewable-first power generation profile. The Pavagada Solar Park, sited on dry land in Tumakuru district, ranks among the world's largest solar installations. Hydro-power generation from the Sharavathi, Kali and Varahi projects functions as the Ghats' battery capacity, though it remains monsoon-dependent. Thermal generation, concentrated in the Raichur-Ballari belt, continues to serve as the state's ageing baseload and is now itself a transition-management problem. The Chitradurga-Gadag wind ridge complements solar generation and generates comparatively less political friction. Free or subsidised electricity for irrigation pumpsets remains the largest hidden — and fiscally significant — energy subsidy in the state, and

⁶⁵PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 37.

⁶⁶PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 38.

⁶⁷PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 39.

combined stress from Electricity Supply Company losses and the Gruha Jyoti free-electricity-unit guarantee is tightening the sector's cash cycle.⁶⁸

E. Telecom Infrastructure

Internet penetration in Karnataka is high by Indian standards but remains a marker of class and geography. Bengaluru operates on fibre and fifth-generation mobile networks and, in effect, assumes ubiquitous high bandwidth as a baseline condition. District headquarters treat fourth-generation connectivity as the default, with service quality rather than coverage as the primary complaint. The Malnad region and the dry north continue to experience significant connectivity gaps, undermining e-governance delivery that depends on reliable signal. The Karnataka State Wide Area Network, gram panchayat Wi-Fi and school connectivity form the less visible infrastructure layer underpinning the Sakala service-delivery commitment. The digital divide that now matters most is not device ownership but upload bandwidth — the difference between completing a Kutumba correction, a tele-medicine consultation, or a Global Capability Centre job from Hubballi rather than from Whitefield in Bengaluru.⁶⁹

Analytical Takeaways – Part VI

1. Infrastructure investment in Karnataka is increasingly bifurcated between Bengaluru-adjacent, access-controlled corridors and a lagging rest-of-state network; the Peripheral Ring Road delay is now a measurable drag on Bengaluru's, and therefore the state's, economic output.
2. The energy sector's free-power-for-irrigation subsidy and the Gruha Jyoti guarantee are compounding, not separate, fiscal pressures on the Electricity Supply Companies; any credible power-sector reform proposal must address both simultaneously.
3. Maritime logistics remains Karnataka's weakest infrastructure vertical relative to peer coastal states, given single-port dependence on New Mangalore; this is a longer-term competitiveness question for the Karavali economy.
4. Telecom quality, not coverage, is now the binding rural-urban divide, with direct consequences for the effectiveness of every digital-governance and social-registry scheme described in Part IV.

⁶⁸PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 40.

⁶⁹PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 41.

IX. Part VII – Economy

A. Fiscal Health Index

Karnataka's Budget for 2026–27 carries a total outlay of ₹4.48 lakh crore, against a revenue deficit of ₹22,957 crore — the third consecutive year of revenue deficit — and a fiscal deficit of ₹97,449 crore, equivalent to 2.95% of Gross State Domestic Product. Outstanding liabilities stand at ₹8.24 lakh crore, or 24.9% of Gross State Domestic Product. On the NITI Aayog Fiscal Health Index for 2023–24, Karnataka ranked ninth among states with a score of 41.7, marking a decline from an earlier Front Runner classification to the Performer category. The five welfare guarantees together account for ₹51,599 crore in a single budget year. Table 3 sets out these headline fiscal indicators.⁷⁰

Indicator	Value	Year
Budget outlay	₹4.48 lakh crore	2026-27
Revenue deficit	₹22,957 crore	2026-27, third straight year
Fiscal deficit	₹97,449 crore (2.95% of GSDP)	2026-27
Outstanding liabilities	₹8.24 lakh crore (24.9% of GSDP)	2026-27
NITI Aayog Fiscal Health Index rank	9th, score 41.7	2023-24
Five guarantees, budgeted cost	₹51,599 crore	2026-27

Table 3: Karnataka fiscal headline indicators. Source: internal PPGF briefing, August 2026, citing Budget 2026-27 and NITI Aayog Fiscal Health Index.

B. CAG Audit Insights

Comptroller and Auditor General audit findings and the NITI Fiscal Health Index both flag Karnataka on the quality of expenditure: committed revenue spending has risen faster than productive capital expenditure. Guarantee accounting, covering more than ₹50,000 crore in near-entitlement spending, requires a multi-year fiscal framework rather than an annual budgetary surprise. Outstanding liabilities remain inside the roughly 25% of Gross State Domestic Product band prescribed under the Karnataka Fiscal Responsibility Act, though the available fiscal room is not unlimited. A recurring political complaint concerns the end of Goods and Services Tax compensation and reduced central tax devolution, set against Karnataka's self-image as a donor state to the Union. Off-budget borrowing through urban and power-sector Special Purpose Vehicles remains a consistent area of Comptroller and Auditor General scrutiny for genuine state debt exposure. Karnataka enacted its own Fiscal Responsibility Act in 2002, making it an early mover on fiscal-rule legislation among Indian states — a statute whose discipline has, on recent evidence, proven stronger than the budgets that have followed it.⁷¹

C. Primary Sector — Agriculture

Karnataka remains a horticulture-driven agricultural economy even as cereal crops continue to dominate political discourse. In 2021–22 district-level production data, Belagavi recorded the largest production volume at 26.4 lakh metric tonnes, while Vijayapura recorded the highest estimated crop loss at ₹399 crore alongside 25.6 lakh metric tonnes of production. Kalaburagi recorded the highest production value at ₹6,457 crore.

⁷⁰PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 42.

⁷¹PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 43.

reflecting its position as pulses country, while Bengaluru Urban, at 2.0 lakh metric tonnes, functions primarily as a consuming rather than a producing district. Coffee, grown principally in Kodagu and Chikkamagaluru, alongside areca, silk, milk and horticulture, now out-earns cereal-based agriculture, even though the farm-power subsidy remains the state's largest untargeted agricultural transfer. Agricultural Produce Market Committee markets, Self-Help Groups and Farmer Producer Organisations are present statewide, though cold-chain infrastructure remains thin.⁷²

D. Primary Sector — Mining

The Sandur-Ballari mining belt holds high-grade haematite iron ore and, for roughly a decade, also functioned as an unofficial political treasury. Illegal-mining cases, Central Empowered Committee findings, Supreme Court production caps and e-auction reforms have since restructured the industry, reducing extraction volume while raising legal compliance. The Kolar Gold Fields now survive as historical memory and a symbol of industrial decline, with tourism and new industrial-area development occupying the former mining sites. Lease allotment processes and Comptroller and Auditor General findings on royalty collection continue to carry the persistent risk of mineral resources being treated as a campaign-finance instrument.⁷³

E. Primary Sector — Fisheries

Karnataka's blue economy spans marine fishing rights along the Karavali coast and inland tank-based fisheries around the Tungabhadra system. A live conflict between purse-seine and traditional fishing gear remains a recurring file for the state's fisheries administration. Landing centres at Mangaluru, Malpe, Karwar and Honnavar function as the sector's real industrial-policy infrastructure. Inland, seed farms, fish nurseries and an unfinished tank-rehabilitation programme continue, alongside poultry-breeding centres that form a quieter inland protein economy. Mechanisation continues to raise both catch volumes and the political temperature of coastal fishing communities.⁷⁴

F. Secondary Sector — Industry

Karnataka's Industrial Policy for 2025–30 targets aerospace, Electronics System Design and Manufacturing, and local-hiring commitments as growth priorities beyond the established information-technology campus model. Bengaluru Rural district hosts 319 industrial units and 1.76 lakh jobs, functioning as the real factory floor of the capital region, while Bengaluru Urban district records the highest project capital expenditure at ₹1.82 lakh crore, alongside the sharpest land-acquisition conflicts. Tumakuru, anchored by the Vasanthanarasapura industrial area with 105 units, functions as the planned industrial twin to Bengaluru. Koppal records ₹1.14 lakh crore in project investment concentrated in steel and bulk manufacturing, generating investment value without a matching density of jobs. Under the Invest Karnataka portal, sector allocation runs to 421 general manufacturing units, 204 industrial parks, 134 food and agri-processing units, 69 Electronics System Design and Manufacturing units, 62 renewable-energy units, and 56 aerospace and defence units.⁷⁵

G. Tertiary Sector — Information Technology Services

⁷²PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 44.

⁷³PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 45.

⁷⁴PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 46.

⁷⁵PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 47.

Karnataka's software exports approach ₹5.5 lakh crore, and in a strong year the state accounts for roughly 40% of India's total software exports, making the sector both the state's fiscal surplus and its principal diplomatic calling card. The state's information-technology policy roadmap seeks to relocate work to Mysuru, Mangaluru and Hubballi, with mixed success to date. Direct information-technology employment, combined with a larger informal services multiplier, effectively constitutes the electoral base of the state's migrant professional class. Global Capability Centre insourcing, artificial intelligence-driven efficiency and competition from other Indian cities are no longer theoretical risks to Bengaluru's dominance but active competitive pressures.⁷⁶

H. Tertiary Sector — Startups and Global Capability Centres

Bengaluru holds the largest single cluster of multinational Global Capability Centres in India, spanning engineering, finance and artificial-intelligence research functions, and ranks among the top two Indian startup ecosystems by funding and by exits, with deep-technology ventures operating alongside consumer-internet businesses. The Indian Institute of Science, the International Institute of Information Technology Bangalore, the Indian Institute of Management Bangalore and a dense private college network feed both the corporate and the startup pipeline. The central structural challenge is that this cluster remains fundamentally a Bengaluru story carrying a Karnataka letterhead; spreading its benefits to the rest of the state is an industrial-policy goal that has repeatedly and politely failed to materialise.⁷⁷

I. Tertiary Sector — Tourism

Karnataka's tourism offering spans five distinct circuits: heritage sites at Hampi, Badami, the Hoysala temples and Bidar; hill destinations in Coorg, Chikkamagaluru and Kodagu; water and coastal destinations at Jog Falls, Gokarna and along the Karavali coast; and wildlife destinations at Bandipur, Nagarahole and the Biligiriranga Tiger Reserve. State grant funding, described in Part II, already maps onto these circuits through the Dasara, Hampi, Kambala and Chalukya festivals. The missing element is not additional festival funding but last-mile hospitality infrastructure — hotel rooms, sanitation and a northern circuit capable of holding an overnight visitor without difficulty.⁷⁸

J. Spatial Governance

Article 371J of the Constitution, granted in 2012, provides a special development status for the former Hyderabad-Karnataka region, now branded Kalyana Karnataka, including local reservation in education and employment and a dedicated development board — a formal acknowledgement that the 1956 unification did not equalise development across the state. The region comprises Bidar, Kalaburagi, Yadgir, Raichur, Koppal and Ballari or Vijayanagara, carrying the continuing political memory of the former Nizam's administration. Raichur and Yadgir feature on NITI Aayog's list of Aspirational Districts, where nutrition, learning outcomes and employment — not headline Gross State Domestic Product — form the relevant scorecard. Allocations under the Kalyana Karnataka Region Development Board and the Hyderabad-Karnataka Area Development Board are closely watched but not always fully absorbed, with administrative capacity representing the principal constraint. This regional divide remains a persistent political fixture: every Chief Minister from Old Mysore

⁷⁶PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 48.

⁷⁷PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 49.

⁷⁸PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 50.

faces the question of what has been done for the north-east, and every Chief Minister from the north-east faces the question of authentic regional belonging.⁷⁹

K. Fiscal Anxieties

The five welfare guarantees, budgeted at ₹51,599 crore for 2026–27, together exceed the combined budget of many state departments. Table 4 sets out the individual guarantee schemes. The underlying academic question is not whether these transfers reduce poverty — the evidence, particularly for Gruha Lakshmi and Shakti, indicates that they do — but whether a revenue-deficit state can sustain them while simultaneously funding the Mekedatu reservoir project and Bengaluru’s tunnel-road infrastructure, and still maintain a capital budget capable of compounding growth. This trade-off is likely to be a central axis of the 2028 Assembly election.⁸⁰

Scheme	Benefit	Budgeted Cost, 2026-27
Gruha Lakshmi	₹2,000 per month to the woman head of household	₹28,608 crore
Gruha Jyoti	Free electricity slab	Part of ₹51,599 crore total
Anna Bhagya	Additional rice on the ration card	Part of ₹51,599 crore total
Shakti	Free bus travel for women	Part of ₹51,599 crore total
Yuva Nidhi	Unemployment allowance for graduates and diploma holders	Part of ₹51,599 crore total

Table 4: The five welfare guarantees. Source: internal PPGF briefing, August 2026, citing Budget 2026-27.

Analytical Takeaways – Part VII

1. Karnataka’s slide from Front Runner to Performer status on the NITI Aayog Fiscal Health Index is the single most important economic-governance fact in this briefing; it converts the guarantee-spending debate from a partisan talking point into a measurable, externally validated fiscal trend.
2. The information-technology and Global Capability Centre economy remains overwhelmingly concentrated in Bengaluru; every industrial-policy document since the 1990s has promised decentralisation and every one has under-delivered, which should temper expectations for the 2025–30 Industrial Policy on this specific point.
3. Kalyana Karnataka’s Article 371J status has not converted into absorbed capital expenditure; capacity-building in district administration in this region is a higher-value intervention than additional funding allocation alone.
4. The ₹51,599 crore guarantee bill will be the central fiscal battleground of the 2028 election; any Government messaging strategy should pre-emptively frame this spending against a credible capital-expenditure commitment rather than leaving the framing to the opposition.

⁷⁹PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 51.

⁸⁰PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 52.

X. Part VIII – Bengaluru

A. Urban Evolution

Bengaluru's development runs through four identifiable phases. Kempe Gowda's fort, established in 1537, began as a plateau town on the Bengaluru-Mysuru axis. Between 1809 and 1847, the establishment of the Cantonment alongside the older pete created two distinct civic cultures that remain visible in the city's built form today. Between the 1950s and 1970s, the public-sector cluster around Hindustan Aeronautics Limited and Indian Telephone Industries built what might be termed the public-sector garden city. From the 1990s onward, software investment, Global Capability Centres and sustained migration have produced a brand that has outgrown the city's physical infrastructure.⁸¹

B. Urban Demographics

Bengaluru Urban district's population exceeds one crore, larger than the population of several Indian states' capital cities, and was likely under-counted in the 2011 Census. The workforce is drawn nationally, and while Kannada remains the official language, it functions as a contested street language in daily civic life. The district recorded a sex ratio of 916 in the 2011 Census, the most masculine ratio among large Indian districts, reflecting a construction-and-technology-sector age and gender structure. The city effectively operates two parallel labour markets — a Global Capability Centre workforce operating in English, and a construction workforce operating in Hindi, Kannada and Bengali — that rarely intersect.⁸²

C. Economic Engine

Bengaluru generates a disproportionate share of Karnataka's own-tax revenue through stamp duty, Goods and Services Tax collection, excise and information-technology-sector salaries, functioning in effect as the state's finance department. The city's corporate cluster runs from Hindustan Aeronautics Limited through Infosys to more than a thousand Global Capability Centres, giving it sufficient depth to absorb the underperformance of any single multinational employer in a given year. Land-based revenue — betterment charges, stamp duty, and the industrial periphery represented by Bengaluru Rural's 319 industrial units — forms a quieter but significant part of the tax base. Nearly every major global firm active in India maintains a Bengaluru office, a combination of genuine soft power and a persistent urban-planning burden.⁸³

D. Urban Crises

Bengaluru's infrastructure bottlenecks have become the defining political brand of the capital. On water, Cauvery supply-stage fluctuations, borewell depletion and informal tanker markets mean that a serious shortage in any given year functions less as an anomaly and more as a rehearsal for the next one. On traffic, peak-hour speeds are widely regarded as inconsistent with a hundred-billion-dollar urban economy; the Metro system serves individual corridors but has not resolved network-wide congestion. On flooding, encroachment of the city's rajakaluve stormwater drains has converted seasonal rainfall into a recurring planning failure. On housing, a Global Capability Centre salary economy and a construction-labour economy occupy overlapping land parcels. On waste and air quality, landfill-site politics at the city's edge and winter air-quality levels now surprise

⁸¹PPGF, "Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance", internal briefing, August 2026, slide 53.

⁸²PPGF, "Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance", internal briefing, August 2026, slide 54.

⁸³PPGF, "Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance", internal briefing, August 2026, slide 55.

residents who had assumed they had left comparable pollution behind in north India. Underlying each of these crises is the governance question addressed in the following section.⁸⁴

E. Local Governance Impasse

Bengaluru last held a full Bruhat Bengaluru Mahanagara Palike council election in 2015. The Greater Bengaluru Governance Act, passed and notified in 2024–25, split the city into five corporations and delimited 369 wards, an increase from the previous 198, but the corporations remain without an election roster or a confirmed poll date as of this briefing. A pending Public Interest Litigation challenges the Greater Bengaluru Authority as an unelected super-municipality under the Seventy-fourth Constitutional Amendment. Two readings of the Act coexist. The administrative reading treats it as a genuine attempt to break up a 709 square-kilometre monopoly that no single mayor could realistically govern. The political reading treats an unelected Greater Bengaluru Authority — in which Members of the Legislative Assembly sit in the room while elected corporators remain outside the executive — as a mechanism for keeping India's richest municipal tax base under direct Secretariat control. Either reading confirms that the Seventy-fourth Amendment was specifically written to prevent an administrator-rule period of this length, and 2026 continues to wait for a ballot.⁸⁵

F. Metro Electoral Dynamics

Bengaluru's 28 Assembly seats behave as a distinct electoral unit rather than a smaller version of the statewide contest. For two decades, the Bharatiya Janata Party treated Bengaluru as a Hindu-middle-class citadel; the 2023 Assembly election punched material holes in that assumption, as guarantee-scheme economics reached apartment-dwelling voters — a breach rather than a full reversal. Local civic failures on garbage collection and flooding compete directly with national television narratives for these voters' attention, and the latter frequently wins the airtime even when the former decides the vote. The Janata Dal (Secular), fundamentally an Old Mysore family party, has limited presence in this urban electorate. Migrant workforce voter enrolment continues to lag the city's actual working population, meaning the city that works in Bengaluru does not always vote in Bengaluru. If civic anger over infrastructure failures persists into 2028, these 28 seats represent the cheapest available opportunity for an opposition party to make gains.⁸⁶

Analytical Takeaways – Part VIII

1. Bengaluru's fiscal contribution and its governance failure are two sides of the same file; a client strategy that addresses one without the other — for example, promising GCC investment without addressing the BBMP election delay — will read as incomplete to informed investors and voters alike.
2. The Greater Bengaluru Governance Act carries genuine constitutional exposure under the Seventy-fourth Amendment; Government should treat an early, credible election roster and date as risk mitigation, not merely as a political concession.
3. The 28 Bengaluru metro Assembly seats are now a swing bloc distinct from the rest of Karnataka's electoral map, and any 2028 strategy document should model them separately from the state's broader caste-arithmetic assumptions.

⁸⁴PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 56.

⁸⁵PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 57.

⁸⁶PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 58.

4. Civic failure — water, traffic, flooding, waste — is Bengaluru's most persuasive and least partisan campaign material; whichever party first builds a credible ward-level delivery machine on these issues, rather than a national-narrative campaign, is best placed to consolidate the capital.

XI. Part IX – Disputes

A. Cauvery Dispute

The Cauvery water dispute has moved through a 1990 tribunal, a 2007 award and a 2018 Supreme Court modification, leaving the law formally settled on paper while it continues to be reopened in every deficit monsoon year. The Cauvery Water Management Authority and the Cauvery Water Regulation Committee function as the peacetime administrative machinery, though distress years reliably convert into street-level politics in Mandya and a diplomatic file in Chennai. Karnataka's proposed Mokedatu balancing reservoir remains at the drawing-board stage; Tamil Nadu reads the project as an attempt to circumvent the existing award. The dispute is no longer confined to agricultural allocation between the two states — Bengaluru's own drinking-water supply stages are now embedded within the same political dynamic. The underlying reason the dispute persists is structural: there is no genuine surplus in the basin, and two water-intensive rice-growing agricultural systems compete with one thirsty metropolis over a finite hydrological cycle.⁸⁷

B. Belagavi Border

The Belagavi, or Belgaum, border dispute with Maharashtra remains open more than six decades after the 1956 States Reorganisation. The Mahajan Commission of 1967 recommended that Belagavi city remain with Mysore, later Karnataka, while certain Marathi-majority villages be transferred to Maharashtra; Maharashtra has never accepted this recommendation. The city itself functions as a genuinely bilingual space, with Kannada as the language of administration alongside a large Marathi-speaking public sphere, and municipal politics capable of flaring into open dispute. Karnataka's practice of holding a winter legislative Assembly session in Belagavi functions as a deliberate claim-making ritual, matched by periodic Maharashtra legislative resolutions on the same territory. The dispute carries no realistic prospect of territorial annexation but remains a permanent identity grievance that both state's political actors reopen whenever a north-Karnataka emotional mobilisation is required.⁸⁸

Analytical Takeaways – Part IX

1. The Cauvery dispute has structurally changed in character: it is no longer purely an inter-state agricultural question but now directly implicates Bengaluru's drinking-water security, raising the stakes for any future Government managing a deficit monsoon year.
2. The Mokedatu project remains the most likely flashpoint for renewed Cauvery-related conflict; Government should treat any acceleration of this project as carrying immediate diplomatic and legal consequences with Tamil Nadu.
3. The Belagavi dispute functions primarily as a symbolic and mobilisational resource rather than an active administrative problem, and should be assessed by political actors accordingly — as identity politics, not as a live boundary-change risk.

⁸⁷PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 59.

⁸⁸PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 60.

XII. Part X – Electoral and Academic

A. Local Body Elections

Gram panchayat elections in Karnataka are held on schedule, and while parties officially maintain non-partisan neutrality at this level, they engage extensively in practice, making the gram panchayat the level at which booth-level party machinery is genuinely maintained. Urban Local Bodies present a sharp contrast: multiple Karnataka cities have operated for extended periods under administrators rather than elected councils, and Bengaluru's is the most prominent but not the only such case. Zilla Panchayat and Taluk Panchayat elections are more overtly partisan, more frequently delayed, and function in practice as a dress rehearsal for Assembly contests. The Bruhat Bengaluru Mahanagara Palike, now the Greater Bengaluru Authority, has missed a full council term, with delimitation completed in 2025 while the election roster and date remain unresolved as of this briefing. Rural local body elections remain on schedule because of the combined effect of the State Election Commission's institutional independence, an established Seventy-third Amendment political culture, and the absence of any Greater Bengaluru Authority-style administrative justification for delay; the cost of the urban delay, by contrast, is that there is no mayor to hold accountable when civic infrastructure fails, and responsibility instead floats upward to the Chief Minister's office, where it tends to dissolve rather than resolve.⁸⁹

B. Local Body Analysis

Civic service delivery functions as Karnataka's uncoded election. Guarantee-scheme delivery operates substantially as a local-body function: the panchayat official who successfully lists a woman for the Gruha Lakshmi scheme is, in practical political terms, doing party work. Urban resident welfare associations and temple networks function as a parallel booth structure to formal party organisation, though this structure is weaker in cities that lack an elected council to organise around. The Janata Dal (Secular) retains a residual family-and-Vokkaliga local presence in Old Mysore taluks, though this presence thins with each successive election cycle. Independent candidates in gram panchayat elections are frequently party-affiliated individuals contesting formally outside party structures — the practical signal to read is the colour of campaign material rather than the candidate's formal affidavit. Sakala and Direct Benefit Transfer delivery have reduced some forms of petty corruption while also reducing the earlier near-monopoly enjoyed by the fixer-oriented Member of the Legislative Assembly. Whichever party first rebuilds Bengaluru's ward-level political machinery will, in practical terms, own the capital's 28 Assembly seats; without that ward machinery, all remaining campaign activity is effectively television advertising.⁹⁰

C. Assembly Map

Karnataka's Vidhana Sabha comprises 224 seats, with a majority requiring 113. Of these, 28 seats fall within the Bengaluru metropolitan area and function, as described in Part VIII, as the hinge for civic-election outcomes across the capital. Each seat elects a single member, and Assembly contests in Karnataka are frequently fought at the level of individual booth organisation.⁹¹

D. Assembly Trends, 2013–2023

⁸⁹PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 61.

⁹⁰PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 62.

⁹¹PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 63.

Karnataka's three most recent Assembly elections have produced three distinct verdicts. In 2013, the Indian National Congress won a majority of 122 seats against a divided opposition. In 2018, the Bharatiya Janata Party emerged as the largest party with 104 seats but fell short of a majority, opening what is commonly described as the state's coalition decade. In 2023, the Indian National Congress returned with 135 seats, driven by the five welfare guarantees and anti-incumbency, while the Janata Dal (Secular) seat count roughly halved. Table 5 sets out the seat trend.⁹²

Year	INC	BJP	JD(S)
2013	122	40	40
2018	80	104	37
2023	135	66	19

Table 5: Karnataka Vidhana Sabha seat trends, 2013-2023. Source: internal PPGF briefing, August 2026, citing Election Commission of India results.

E. Assembly Dynamics

Two structural facts govern Karnataka Assembly outcomes: votes do not translate proportionally into seats, and incumbency does not translate into safety. In the 2023 election, the Indian National Congress converted a 42.9% vote share into a 60.3% seat share, an efficiency gain of roughly 17 percentage points. The Bharatiya Janata Party converted a 36.0% vote share into only a 29.5% seat share, reflecting wasted votes concentrated in suburban constituencies. The Janata Dal (Secular) converted a 13.3% vote share into an 8.5% seat share, a concentrated but shrinking presence. Other parties and independents together held 7.8% of the vote but only 1.8% of seats, functioning as electoral noise rather than an organised bloc. No party has secured a comfortable second consecutive full term in the modern era without a mid-course political crisis or a coalition realignment: the 2013 Congress majority was followed by defeat in 2018, and the 2018 Bharatiya Janata Party plurality was followed by collapse in 2023. This pattern implies a structural headwind heading into 2028 for whichever party then holds Vidhana Soudha — presently the Congress party under Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar — with any exception likely to be earned specifically in Bengaluru and in the management of the guarantee-scheme ledger.⁹³

F. 2023 Assembly Analysis

The Congress party's 135-seat victory in 2023 rested on identifiable campaign mechanics rather than a generalised political wave. The offer consisted of five written welfare guarantees, forming a manifesto simple enough to be recited at a bus stop — a rare degree of message clarity. The anger drew on a persistent forty per cent commission allegation against the preceding Government, which functioned simultaneously as a middle-class and a rural corruption narrative. The AHINDA-plus-women coalition combined Dr Siddaramaiah's established social bloc with a female-headed transfer scheme, Gruha Lakshmi, that had been designed in advance of the vote. The Janata Dal (Secular)'s decline reflected both family-politics fatigue and a flirtation with the Bharatiya Janata Party that cost it seats in Old Mysore that had previously gone to the party as a genuine third pole. Bharatiya Janata Party errors included an over-reliance on Lingayat consolidation, urban complacency, and a Chief Minister who had inherited Shri B.S. Yediyurappa's party organisation without his

⁹²PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 64.

⁹³PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 65.

ease of caste relationships. The final seat mathematics converted a 42.9% vote share into 60% of seats, concentrated in Old Mysore and in a rebound across Kalyana Karnataka.⁹⁴

G. Power Transitions

D.K. Shivakumar was sworn in as Chief Minister of Karnataka on 3 June 2026, honouring an informal 2023 power-sharing pact that had been denied for approximately three years before finally being implemented. G. Parameshwara continues as Deputy Chief Minister, maintaining Dalit representation within a Vokkaliga-led Cabinet. Dr Yathindra S., son of former Chief Minister Dr Siddaramaiah, retains a Cabinet berth, keeping the AHINDA household within Government. The transition is best read as caste statecraft rather than purely as a matter of individual personality: a Kuruba and AHINDA-aligned Chief Minister yields office to a Vokkaliga organisational leader; a Dalit Deputy Chief Minister provides political glue; and the former Chief Minister's son provides a form of political insurance. The risk in this arrangement is the presence of two power centres within a single legislature party with the 2028 election already a live consideration; the corresponding opportunity is an Old Mysore consolidation that Dr Siddaramaiah, as an individual, could never personally embody. The Bharatiya Janata Party's stated hope is a visibly messy transition; the Congress party's hope is that the combination of continued welfare guarantees and a new leadership face resets accumulated anti-incumbency.⁹⁵

H. Parliamentary Map

Karnataka sends 28 members to the Lok Sabha through a coarser, more nationalised electoral map than the Assembly. Across the 2014, 2019 and 2024 general elections, the Bharatiya Janata Party has won 17, 25 and 17 seats respectively; the Indian National Congress has won 9, 1 and 9 seats respectively; and the Janata Dal (Secular), contesting as a National Democratic Alliance ally in 2024, has won 2, 1 and 2 seats respectively.⁹⁶

I. Lok Sabha Trends, 2014–2024

Karnataka's Lok Sabha results demonstrate that Delhi is not Vidhana Soudha. The 2014 general election, fought on a Modi-led national wave, delivered 17 seats to the Bharatiya Janata Party, establishing the party's southern beachhead. The 2019 general election marked the party's peak performance, with 25 seats against a near wipe-out of the Indian National Congress at 1 seat. The 2024 general election showed a reversion toward the mean, with the Bharatiya Janata Party at 17 seats, the Indian National Congress at 9 seats, and the Janata Dal (Secular) at 2 seats as part of the National Democratic Alliance. Table 6 sets out this trend.⁹⁷

Year	BJP	INC	JD(S)
2014	17	9	2
2019	25	1	1
2024	17	9	2

Table 6: Karnataka Lok Sabha seat trends, 2014-2024. Source: internal PPGF briefing, August 2026, citing Election Commission of India results.

J. Dual Voting Behaviour

⁹⁴PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 66.
⁹⁵PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 67.
⁹⁶PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 68.
⁹⁷PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 69.

Karnataka's electorate displays clear split-ticket behaviour, arguably the most consequential and least utilised fact in the state's political analysis. In the 2023 Assembly election, the Indian National Congress won 135 seats to the Bharatiya Janata Party's 66, on a state-level contest fought over rice, electricity, bus travel and a corruption allegation. Twelve months later, in the 2024 Lok Sabha election, the same electorate returned 17 seats to the Bharatiya Janata Party against 9 for the Indian National Congress, on a national security and welfare-framed ballot. This is not a contradiction: Karnataka voters routinely separate their choice of Chief Minister from their choice of Prime Minister, and the 2018–19 election cycle showed the identical pattern in reverse. The Janata Dal (Secular)'s National Democratic Alliance alliance in the 2024 general election helped the Bharatiya Janata Party in Old Mysore parliamentary seats that the party cannot win independently in an Assembly contest. The clear implication is that a 2028 Assembly election will not simply replay 2024 Lok Sabha dynamics, and any campaign that nationalises every state issue risks forfeiting this demonstrated split-ticket advantage.⁹⁸

K. 2028 Vidhan Sabha Outlook

This section presents an academic strategy assessment of what a Bharatiya Janata Party recovery in the 2028 Assembly election would genuinely require, rather than a partisan campaign document. First, the party would need to avoid nationalising the Assembly contest: the 2023 election was lost on state issues while the 2024 general election was won on national ones, and conflating the two produced the 135-seat Congress outcome. Second, the party would need to make Bengaluru's civic failures — floods, water-tank management, bus transport and the Greater Bengaluru Authority election delay — its own issue, addressing the capital's genuine anger without adopting a national television studio tone. Third, the party would need to reopen the Lingayat conversation: the 2008–18 coalition of religious mathas that anchored Bharatiya Janata Party support has weakened, and neither the Panchamasali sub-caste assertion nor the post-Shri B.S. Yediyurappa leadership has yet produced a fresh political narrative. Fourth, the party would need to treat the Janata Dal (Secular) as a scalpel rather than a crutch: useful in specific Old Mysore Lok Sabha seats, but risky in an Assembly contest where it can hand the Congress party a convenient 'family versus people' framing. Fifth, the party would need to price the welfare guarantees credibly rather than dismiss them, offering a cheaper and better-targeted transfer alternative, particularly to women heads of household, rather than mocking the existing scheme. Sixth, the party would need to improve candidate quality in southern Karnataka, since ticket-allocation arrogance in 2023 cost more seats than any single campaign slogan, and Old Mysore contests are won at the level of individual booths.⁹⁹

Analytical Takeaways – Part X

1. The consistent one-term-and-out pattern across the last three Assembly elections is Karnataka's single most reliable electoral fact and should be the starting assumption for any 2028 planning document, regardless of which party commissions it.
2. Split-ticket voting between Assembly and Lok Sabha elections is well-documented and under-exploited; campaign strategy that nationalises a state election, or localises a national one, works against the electorate's demonstrated behaviour.

⁹⁸PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 70.

⁹⁹PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slide 71.

3. The D.K. Shivakumar-G. Parameshwara-Yathindra S. cabinet arrangement manages, but does not resolve, the risk of dual Congress power centres; this is the single most important intra-party variable to track ahead of 2028.
4. The Bengaluru metro's 28 Assembly seats are the most persuadable bloc in the state and should be modelled and campaigned separately from the caste-arithmetic assumptions that structure the rest of Karnataka's Assembly map.

XIII. Conclusions

A. State Synergy and Growth Assets

Karnataka's growth assets compound regardless of which party holds office. The technology cluster — information technology, Global Capability Centres, startups and the Indian Institute of Science — represents a globally rare urban capability that continues to deepen. The coast and the Western Ghats combine port infrastructure, hydro-power capacity, coffee cultivation, tourism potential and a UNESCO-recognised ecology that remains under-productised relative to its scale. The state's human capital sits at a total fertility rate of 1.7, below replacement level, alongside a deep engineering talent bench. Karnataka's public digital infrastructure — Bhoomi, Kutumba, Sakala and Khajane — gives the state a genuine capacity to identify and reach its citizens that few other Indian states can match. Industrial depth in aerospace, Electronics System Design and Manufacturing, automotive and electric-vehicle manufacturing and food-processing parks means the 2025–30 Industrial Policy is not starting from a blank position. Soft power, running from Hampi through Kantara to the Mysuru Dasara festival, gives the state a recognisable civilisation-economy brand.¹⁰⁰

B. Developmental Bottlenecks

Three binds constrain Karnataka's development regardless of which Government is in office. The regional bind is that Kalyana Karnataka remains a constitutional special case under Article 371J precisely because it remains a development special case; the 371J provision is a mirror reflecting the underlying disparity rather than a solution to it, and a guarantee state funded by Bengaluru's surplus that cannot adequately staff a Primary Health Centre in Yadgir will continue to fail its own internal map. The fiscal bind is that a revenue deficit combined with ₹51,600 crore in welfare guarantees and a debt-to-Gross State Domestic Product ratio of 25% is manageable as a single-year position but is not sustainable as a permanent operating regime; capital expenditure on water, transit and higher education is precisely what the state's fiscal surplus was intended to fund. The urban bind is that Bengaluru's water supply, its unheld municipal elections and its broader governance politics have become a single, combined risk to Gross State Domestic Product; a state that cannot elect a council in its own capital sends a governance-failure signal to every Global Capability Centre it is simultaneously trying to attract and retain.¹⁰¹

C. Final Synthesis

Karnataka's future is not a question of resource scarcity. It is a question of distribution — of water between the Cauvery basin's competing users, of Cabinet berths between the Vokkaliga and AHINDA wings of the ruling coalition, of municipal power between an elected council and an appointed authority, and of the Bengaluru fiscal surplus between the capital and the rest of the state. The 2026 leadership transition resets the caste arithmetic within the Congress party. It does not reset the underlying drought map, the unresolved Cauvery file, or the missing Bruhat Bengaluru Mahanagara Palike vote. These three unresolved questions are likely to shape the outcome of the 2028 election more directly and more durably than any single campaign slogan.¹⁰²

¹⁰⁰PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slides 72–74.

¹⁰¹PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slides 72–74.

¹⁰²PPGF, “Karnataka: State Overview – Policy, Politics & Governance”, internal briefing, August 2026, slides 72–74.